

THE GODLY PATH OF LEAST RESISTANCE:

A Step-by-Step Guide for Living by the Lord's Prayer



By Matt Wilson

Foreword by Governor Mike Huckabee



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DEDICATION & ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS



This book is for the Glory of my Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.

In addition, this book is for my wife (who proofread this book), my son (who prayed for “Daddy to do good on his book” almost every night), my parents, my sisters, and the rest of my family.

Finally, I would like to thank my friends from law school and co-workers (past and present) who critiqued this volume, and Governor Huckabee for writing such a kind foreword.

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Additionally, the following book is not a solicitation for legal business. The sole purpose of this book is to expound upon theological subjects. To the extent that legal analysis is used in said discussions, such analysis is purely ancillary.

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FOREWORD



Matt Wilson was a bright and ambitious college student when he approached me in early 1998 with a desire to assist in my reelection campaign for Governor of Arkansas. I was immediately impressed with the details of his plan for an outreach to students, and by his depth both intellectually and spiritually. Through the years, I've watched with real admiration as he has continued his journey through college, law school, and as an exemplary young husband and father. My respect for him has only grown through the years.

In his insightful book about the Lord's Prayer, Matt brings a very refreshing simplicity to an often quoted, but rarely understood section of the New Testament which we commonly call, "The Lord's Prayer." It doesn't surprise me that Matt would write a wonderful book of encouragement. It would only surprise me if it wasn't soon a favorite of those who read it!

Mike Huckabee, Governor of Arkansas, 1996-2007

INTRODUCTION



After this manner therefore pray ye:

Our Father which art in heaven,
Hallowed be thy name.
Thy kingdom come.
Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread.
And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
But deliver us from evil:
For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the
glory, for ever.
Amen.

Matthew 6:9-13

In the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus instructs humanity in the proper manner of prayer. Although Christians over the centuries have recited the “Lord’s Prayer” (or the “Model Prayer”) from memory during church services and at bedtime, I dare say that most Christians have failed to grasp the true reason why we are instructed to pray in this particular manner.

Every command, whether from God's law or from man's law, has both a procedural and a substantive component. Every law or regulation incorporates both the letter and the spirit.

Although the Pharisees mastered the procedural aspects of the Old Testament, they failed to comprehend the substantive nature of these rules. For instance, they understood that at sundown on Friday all work had to cease for twenty-four hours. They followed the procedural rules concerning the Sabbath to the letter. However, they missed the substantive point of the Law; they missed the very reason why God had created a Sabbath in the first place: to give man a day of rest. So when Jesus dared to lift the burdens of sickness and disease from the blind and lame, the Pharisees were enraged that Jesus did so on the Sabbath. Although Jesus was bringing rest to the weary on the day of rest, He was deemed a heretic because He wasn't resting.

With the Lord's Prayer, the same procedural and substantive elements are present. Accordingly, we must be careful not to fall into the same trap the Pharisees fell. We should not embrace the procedural to the exclusion of the substantive. In other words, we should not feel like this is the only prayer we are allowed to pray to God. We should not feel compelled to recite the Lord's Prayer—and only the Lord's Prayer—when we pray. Otherwise, we will miss the substance of what Jesus is trying to teach us.

By this same token, as we begin to explore the substantive elements of the Lord's Prayer we should not completely forgo its procedural aspects, either. For example, even though Jesus expounded upon the substantive elements of the Law in the Sermon on the Mount (and in His other teachings), Jesus did not completely discard the procedural requirements of the Old Testament. On the contrary, while dying on the cross, Jesus fulfilled the ceremonial and procedural

requirements of the Law by becoming the ultimate sacrifice for sin. (*See Hebrews 10:10.*)

When studying the Lord's Prayer, we should not discard the procedural aspects of the teaching. In other words, we should recognize that Jesus placed "and lead us not into temptation" after "and forgive us our debts" for a reason. Likewise, we should understand that there is a reason why we should pray for God's Name to be hallowed before we pray for His Will to be done on Earth. Although we should not be legalistic in how we pray, we should certainly recognize that Jesus taught us to pray "after this manner" for a reason.

With that said, what could this reason (or perhaps, these reasons) be? What is the Lord attempting to communicate to humanity by laying out the Model Prayer in the way that He has modeled it?

Immediately before explaining to the crowd the proper manner in which to pray, Jesus declared, "[Y]our Father knoweth what things ye have need of, before ye ask him." (Matthew 6:8) From this, we may glean that the purpose of prayer is not to give God updates on our problems; indeed, He already knows what our problems are. Instead, the purpose of prayer is to demonstrate the very condition of our hearts.

Jesus taught that "out of the abundance of the heart the mouth speaketh." (Matthew 12:34) When we pray, we are communicating to God what is inside our hearts. Normally, the first words that come out of our mouths during prayer relate to the very subjects that are the nearest to our hearts. Indeed, our prayers reveal a great deal about who we are and what we really want from God. Thus, if our hearts are right with God, our prayers will reflect the strength of our relationship. Conversely, if our hearts are impure, then our prayers will reflect the nature of our true motives.

The basic theme of this book is that: (1) God wants each of us to develop certain character traits; that (2) God will

sometimes allow us to enter unpleasant situations so that we may develop these particular characteristics; *but that* (3) as we develop these character traits—and by extension, as our prayers begin to reflect the transformation of our hearts to this end—it will become less necessary for God to lead us into such unpleasant situations.

Put another way, God wants to teach us certain lessons. We may choose to learn these lessons the easy way or the hard way. This book is for those who want to learn the easy way.

I believe that the Lord's Prayer is, in and of itself, a lesson for humanity. The Lord's Prayer is a blueprint for our lives. If we learn—rather, if we master—each and every lesson contained in the Lord's Prayer, we will follow “The Godly Path of Least Resistance.”

If we master each element of the Model Prayer (*i.e.*, the substantive) in the order that they are presented (*i.e.*, the procedural), then we will avoid all of the *unnecessary* pitfalls in life, and we will be delivered from all the troubles for which we must endure as Christians.

Metaphorically, each element of the Lord's Prayer is like a college semester, where we learn an important lesson that builds upon the previous lessons that we have learned.

In the first semester of college, an engineering student (which I once was) must learn foundational subjects, such as Calculus I and Physics I. If these foundational subjects are not learned, the engineering student will have to repeat these classes—or else change his major. Likewise, we will not “pass” our first semester in the study of the Lord's Prayer until we realize that God is our Father and that He is in Heaven. If we fail to grasp the full import of this concept, we will not be able to advance to the next level.

In the second semester, an engineering student learns more about calculus and physics. Naturally, the second semester is more complicated than the first, hence the reason

a student cannot skip to Calculus II without understanding Calculus I. Likewise, a person may not advance to Calculus III without passing Calculus II. By this same token, when we learn how to humble ourselves and to exalt God's reputation (*i.e.*, God's Name) even at the expense of our own standing, then we will have "passed" the second semester; however, if we do not learn this lesson, we may not advance to the next level.

As we advance through the proverbial semesters, every lesson we learn will build upon previous lessons until we finally walk in the total and complete victory that God's Word promises. Then we shall declare from personal experience that God has "the kingdom, the power, and the glory for ever. Amen."

Chapter
FIRST SEMESTER:
“OUR FATHER WHICH ART IN HEAVEN”



The foundational lesson—the building block for any discussion of the Lord’s Prayer—is the revelation that God is (1) our Father and that (2) He is in Heaven. Unless this construct is sown into the heart of the petitioner, the rest of the prayer becomes useless babble.

Although we refer to God as “our Father,” we have no real way of knowing what God’s gender really is—if He even has a gender. Perhaps I am wrong, but I find it difficult to believe that God, who is a Spirit (*see* John 4:24), would have need for the biological accoutrements that run appurtenant to being a male (or a female for that matter). Since God can speak life into existence (*see* Genesis 1-2), He has little need, if any, for reproductive organs. Therefore, from a purely biological standpoint, I doubt that we can truly say God has a gender. Nevertheless, God has chosen to reveal Himself as a man, more particularly as a Father to civilization. I believe He has done so for a reason.

Being all-powerful, God could have revealed Himself as a female. At the very least, He could have created Eve first, forming Adam out of *her* rib, therefore causing the woman to become the head of the man. (*Cf.* I Corinthians 11:8.) Instead, God revealed Himself as a man. He made

Adam first, deriving Eve from Adam's rib. (*See* Genesis 2.) Therefore, regardless of whether God is male in all respects, or whether He has merely chosen to reveal Himself as such, God is for all intents and purposes a *He* and not a *She*.

Accordingly, if we are to pass the proverbial first semester of our study, we must examine the characteristics that distinguish men from women. In particular, we must contrast the parental attributes of a father from that of a mother. Through these juxtapositions, we will understand more about God's character, and we will comprehend more about what it means to have God as "our Father."

When Jesus was about thirty years old, He went to the Jordan River to be baptized by John the Baptist. Although John at first had objected to Jesus' request, the desert evangelist relented when Jesus explained that His baptism was necessary "to fulfil all righteousness." (Matthew 3:15)

As soon as John finished the ceremony, even as Jesus was leaving the water, the heavens opened and the audible voice of God exclaimed, "This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased." (Matthew 3:17) After Jesus had fulfilled all righteousness by being baptized, God the Father could hardly hold back His excitement: He had to tell the world that He loved Jesus and that He was very proud of His Son.

Isn't that just like a father? Whenever Junior does something that truly pleases his Daddy, his Daddy will tell the whole world about it if he can. I know that I am like that.

My son is at the age where he is just beginning to do certain things on his own. No, he's not driving or dating by any means; he is still only seven years old. He is, however, maturing faster in some areas than I had anticipated. Whenever he does something that indicates, shall we say, "wisdom beyond his years," or skills beyond his age-level, I immediately feel the compelling urge to tell the world about it.

For example, when he was about three years old, he was learning how to use my computer. One evening, I forgot to disconnect my internet connection. My son went into the computer room, started playing with my web browser, and the next thing I knew, he had downloaded and installed the newest version of RealPlayer®. Naturally, I was excited. Even though my son didn't know how to read, even though he probably had hit a random pop-up advertisement and continued pressing "OK" when prompted, he still did something that was amazing for a three year-old. I immediately told my friends about what my beloved son had done. Even now, I am so impressed that I am mentioning it in this book.

Fathers tend to glory in their children's accomplishments. At baseball games, when Junior steps up to the plate, Daddy is the first one to cheer when the ball is knocked over the fence. However, when Junior strikes out, Daddy will be the first person to remind him to keep his eye on the ball and to follow through with his swing the next time he is at bat.

I don't believe that God is any different, except that, I suppose, when God the Father glories in His children, it is not because of what we have done; instead, it's because of what we have become on the inside. Have we succeeded in forming a relationship with God? Have we become more like Him? Have we "fulfilled all righteousness," so to speak? If so, God will be pleased—so pleased that He will feel compelled to proclaim just how proud He is of us.

When Jesus fulfilled all righteousness, *i.e.*, when Jesus had done everything necessary to be in good standing with His Father, God wanted to brag about His Boy. Likewise, when we succeed in fulfilling all righteousness, God will also brag on us. Perhaps He won't part the clouds and speak with an audible voice, but He will make His pleasure known to people who are around us. He will pour His favor out upon our lives.

This invites an interesting question. How do we mere mortals “fulfill all righteousness”?

The first thing we must keep in mind is that being righteous before God is an all-or-nothing proposition. We are righteous, or we are unrighteous; there is no in between. We must either be hot or cold. (*See* Revelation 3:16.)

The second thing we must realize is that without the assistance of God, righteousness is unattainable. The Bible says that our righteousness is as filthy rags. (*See* Isaiah 64:6.) As fallen human beings we are unrighteous by our very nature; therefore, we are incapable of fulfilling all righteousness by our own efforts.

No matter how much we pray, no matter how much we go to church, no matter how much money we give to the poor or to fund the Gospel, we are incapable of becoming righteous, absent the grace of God working in our hearts. “Can the Ethiopian change his skin, or the leopard his spots? then may ye also do good, that are accustomed to do evil.” (Jeremiah 13:23)

The good news, however, is that Jesus Christ, who did fulfill all righteousness, has offered to exchange His Righteousness for ours. When Jesus died on the cross, God put our sins upon Him so that we might be made the Righteousness of God in Christ. (*See* II Corinthians 5:21)

When we stop trying to establish our own righteousness, when we accept the Righteousness of God that is available through faith in Christ, we will become as righteous as Jesus is. (*See id.*) All we have to do is to believe in our hearts—not our heads, mind you, but in our hearts—that Jesus Christ was raised from the dead. (*See* Romans 10:13.) When this faith is birthed in our hearts, we will have accepted God’s Righteousness through Christ.

Many fail to grasp this concept because they confuse righteousness with external perfection. When a person accepts Christ, such a one may have God’s Righteousness

on the inside (*i.e.*, within his heart) but still live an imperfect life. Remember that the Righteousness of Christ is more akin to a status than it is to a particular pattern of behavior.

Perhaps the best way to describe this paradigm is to examine the concept of natural citizenship—particularly as it relates to citizenship in the United States of America. Under the present interpretation of the Fourteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution, every person born in the United States is an American citizen. Thus if a pregnant tourist from France were to give birth to her baby daughter in New York City, the child would automatically become an American citizen.

Now, if this little girl were to leave for France with her mother and live there for the rest of her life, she would still be a United States citizen. She could speak French and never learn English. She could wear those weird looking berets. She could devour escargot and pate while sipping red wine by the Eiffel Tower. Yet, she would remain a United States citizen unless and until she renounces her citizenship.

Likewise, when we accept Christ into our hearts, we immediately become righteous. We immediately become citizens of Heaven. However, since we are living on Earth—a place that has a completely different culture than the one found in Heaven—we may tend to live like the world around us. Our actions may not always align with what is written on our hearts. In the same way that a natural-born United States citizen who is raised in France may not act like an American, a Christian may sometimes behave like a citizen of Earth and not like a citizen of Heaven.

Nevertheless, although our behavior does not define our righteousness, our righteousness must define our behavior. For starters, we are living in a world that is waging war against God. If we fall back in love with this world, we may choose to abandon our faith. In the same way that a girl raised in France may embrace French culture to the point

where she chooses to renounce her American birthright, we too may embrace the worldliness that surrounds us and reject the sacrifice that Christ has made for us. (*See* Hebrews 6.)

On the other hand, even if our citizenship in Heaven is forever secure, as many Christians believe (and as I, too, once held), it remains necessary for God's Righteousness to expand from our hearts to our minds, and then from our minds to our actions. Unless God's Righteousness is made manifest in our actions, we will never experience the full benefits of God's favor on our lives. Although we may be entitled to such favor, we will never be positioned to experience it fully; we will never experience the full kingdom, power and glory of God in our lives, nor will we be able to share these blessings with the world around us.

Once we have embraced the Righteousness of God through faith in Christ—once we have abandoned all hope of becoming righteous in our own strength—we will have fulfilled all righteousness. Our status will have changed. We will no longer be dead in our sins; rather, we will be alive in Christ. Instead of being destined to perpetual defeat, we will be able to overcome our failures—our shortcomings—and do right by God.

Just as "Abraham believed God, and it was counted unto him for righteousness" (Romans 4:3), so shall Christ's Righteousness be imputed into our hearts when we put our faith and trust in His sacrificial offering. From God's perspective, we will become as righteous as Jesus was when He came out of the water. Then we will know that God loves us and that He is well pleased with us.

Understanding that we have a Father who is pleased with us is half the battle. Now we must understand that our Father is in Heaven.

Not only is God our Father; He is also the King of the universe. By simply opening His mouth, the entire universe

was created from scratch. That's how powerful He is. That's how powerful His Words are.

When God speaks into our hearts that He is well-pleased with us, when He speaks into our hearts that we have fulfilled all righteousness, His Words will perform a magnificent work not unlike that of Creation itself. In the same way that God's Words created the universe from nothing, so shall His Words create life in our hearts. Even as God's Words erased darkness by creating light, so shall His Words erase the self-doubt and anxiety that clouds our deepest, most intimate thoughts. If God's Words can create life out of nothing, so will His Words create life out of the formless void of pain and anguish. When He says that He is pleased with us, who cares what anyone else thinks?

The fact that God is in Heaven is important for another reason. God is the epitome of objective truth. Although He is as close as a prayer, He is far enough away from our situations that He can look at our lives—at our problems—with a fresh perspective. He is not so blinded by His love or by His emotions that He would jeopardize what is right—what is holy—for that which is convenient. He is, after all, “our” father—not just “your” father or “my” father.

I believe this is why God is our Father and not our Mother.

Dr. Simon Baron-Cohen is the director of the Autism Research Centre at Cambridge University. In a 2003 article published in *The Guardian*, Dr. Baron-Cohen theorizes “that the female brain is predominantly hard-wired for empathy, and that the male brain is predominantly hard-wired for understanding and building systems.”¹ He explains further (using British spelling):

Empathising is the drive to identify another person's emotions and thoughts, and to respond to these with an appropriate emotion. The empathiser intuitively

figures out how people are feeling, and how to treat people with care and sensitivity. Systemising is the drive to analyse and explore a system, to extract underlying rules that govern the behaviour of a system; and the drive to construct systems. The systemiser intuitively figures out how things work, or what the underlying rules are controlling a system.²

On the average, men tend to react to situations logically, whereas women tend to react emotionally. For example, when a child is sick, a typical mother will focus upon the child's feelings. She will try to bring immediate comfort to the child. Under similar circumstances, however, a typical father will examine the underlying reason for the ailment. Although he certainly loves his child and wants the little boy or girl to feel better, he will try to rectify the problem, even if it means exacerbating the child's discomfort. So when a doctor gives a child an injection, Mom will likely hold the child's hand, and Dad will likely say, "Tough it out."

Of course, this is not to say that men cannot be emotional or that women can never be logical. There are manifold exceptions to this observation. In just about any prison, one can find men who have committed manslaughter during fits of rage. Conversely, I am sure that some women over the years have figured ways to commit premeditated murder without being caught.

Certainly, God has given both sexes the ability to express not only their thoughts, but their emotions as well. Sometimes thoughts and feelings are expressed through acts of love, such as tending to a sick child. In other instances, thoughts and feelings are expressed through acts of violence, such as homicide. Regardless, thoughts or feelings—whether good or bad—may be expressed by men and women alike. However, as science would show, women tend to default to feelings, whereas men tend to default to logic.

If God were to view the world from the perspective of the typical mother (*i.e.*, from a perspective that defaults to emotion rather than logic), God might be inclined to bring comfort to our situations without addressing the underlying causes for our problems.

Although God is love (*see* I John 4:8), God is also the Creator. (*See* Genesis 1:1.) Although God empathizes with our hurts, His larger plan transcends our need for comfort. When something is broken, God does not wish to address merely the symptoms; He desires to fix the problem. Since humanity's problem is rebellion from God, it would be counterproductive for God to neutralize the consequences of our sin without first demanding repentance therefrom.

I know this is speculation, but I suppose this "holy paternalism" could explain why an infinitely loving God would allow as much suffering as this world has seen: It's our mess, not His. Although He will happily show us how to fix our problems and give us everything necessary to complete the task, He still wants us to do the work. To paraphrase my high school football and basketball coaches, "Mamma ain't here to clean up our messes."

Thus, if we want God to move on our behalves, we have to ask Him. We simply cannot expect Him to move on His own. Yes, He is sovereign. No, He doesn't need our permission to act. (He is, after all, God.) Nevertheless, He is a Father, and like all fathers, God is not going to clean our messes without our involvement. Even when the problem is not one of our own making, God will still demand our participation. Otherwise, if God were to solve our problems spontaneously, how would we learn anything? How would we develop any character?

The good news is that since God is our Heavenly Father, we have a very powerful ally when we pray. When we ask Him to move in our midst, He will. Metaphorically speaking, we do not have to clean our rooms by ourselves.

Like any loving father, He longs to build a relationship with His children. He wants to spend time with us. He wants to fellowship with us. Accordingly, we have access to the Throne of Grace whenever we have need of Him. (*See* Hebrews 4:16.) He is not going to shut the door of His Presence to any person who truly desires to fellowship with Him—*i.e.*, to share in the benefits and the responsibilities of His Righteousness. If we desire to implement God's Plan and Purpose—*i.e.*, His Righteousness—on this Earth, God will help us, meeting our every need in the process.

God will withhold no good thing from those who walk in His Righteousness. (*See* Psalm 84:11.) When we, His children, ask for that which is good, He will not give us something that is bad. (*See* Matthew 7:9.) He loves us more than we could ever love ourselves. Sometimes, though, we ask God for things that are not good. Sometimes we do not have the big picture, and we ask for things that would undermine God's Plan and Purpose. When this happens, our Heavenly Father reserves the right to say "no" to our petitions. (*See* James 4:3.) However, if we pray according to His Will, we know that He will answer our prayers. (*See* I John 5:14.) Naturally, there is no better way to pray according to God's Will than to follow the example of the Model Prayer.

This may seem like an oversimplification of how God interacts with humanity. Frankly, it may well be. No book, certainly not this one, can explain the wonder that is God. However, Jesus often used parables to explain the complex nature of our Heavenly Father and His Kingdom. In that spirit, I have attempted to illustrate how God appropriates love and wisdom simultaneously. As much satisfaction as fathers have in solving problems for their children, they have even greater satisfaction when their children solve problems for themselves—especially when they ask for Daddy's help. While I may be wrong, I surmise that God is no different.

Of course, the problems that we face in life are often too big for us to handle. We need God's help just as we need the air we breathe or the water we drink. Therefore, we must come boldly before His throne and reason with Him if we expect God to move in our midst. (*See Hebrews 4:16, Isaiah 1:18.*) However, when we do pray, we should stand ready to accept marching orders from our Father, because He will demand our participation.

Furthermore, if we wish to be effective in our prayers, then it would behoove us to follow the blueprint that He has given us: the Model Prayer.

Chapter
SECOND SEMESTER:
“HALLOWED BE THY NAME”



Once we understand that God has infinite love coupled with supreme objectivity—once we realize that His love is perfectly and indivisibly entwined with His holiness—only then may we advance to the next lesson in our study of the Model Prayer. Only then may we comprehend what it means to pray, “Hallowed be Thy Name.”

In Proverbs we are taught, “A good name is rather to be chosen than great riches, and loving favour rather than silver and gold.” (22:1) In common parlance, a “good name” equates to a good reputation. Thus, King Solomon teaches in this passage that a good reputation is more valuable than great riches, and that loving favor is more valuable than silver and gold.

Since “great riches” equates to “silver and gold,” it is clear from the context of this passage that King Solomon associates a good name—or a good reputation—with loving favor. Moreover, in the Hebrew, loving favor means “grace” or “acceptance.”³ Thus, the wise king implies that a person who possesses a good reputation will enjoy grace and loving acceptance. Furthermore, the grace that comes from a good reputation is more valuable than riches. After all, there are some things that money cannot buy.

Now, if we juxtapose this passage against what we have learned in the last chapter, *i.e.*, that our righteousness is as filthy rags, it would stand to reason that our individual reputations, *i.e.*, our respective names, are just as despicable as our righteousness. If we could never measure to the righteous standard of an infinitely loving but perfectly objective God, then how could we by our own reputation ever earn God's loving favor? Certainly, if our righteousness were like a piece of cloth resting in a dumpster, our reputation would be as the putrid smell emanating from the sewer.

When compared to God Almighty, none of us—not a single one of us—has a good name. Oh yes, we may have prodigious reputations in our respective fields. Some of us may be celebrated actors or broadcasters or athletes; some of us may be respected businessmen or politicians or community leaders. But to the extent that we may be celebrated—to the extent that we may feel on top of the world—it is because we are the big fish in a pond that is too small for God to swim.

Relative to God's holiness and truth, none of us deserves grace—none of us deserves loving favor—because none of our individual names has intrinsic value. For example, my name doesn't move God because my reputation is worthless when compared to His. In the same way that a corporate CEO would hardly respond to the supplication of a homeless orphan living on the streets of Los Angeles, so would it be absurd for God to drop everything because "Yours Truly" asks for His assistance. (The same holds true for your name as well.)

Nevertheless, God does respond to our prayers when we pray in Jesus' Name. When we come to the Father in the Name above all names—when we come to God using the Name of His only Son—He will move. Although our righteousness is as filthy rags, even though our reputations are worthless, when we invoke the Name of Jesus, when we come to God

in the Name of the most righteous person to ever walk the face of the Earth, God becomes so impressed that He overlooks our sin and moves in our midst. From God's perspective, the Name of Jesus is so hallowed, so glorified that Its very mention invites the loving favor of the Father God.

It's no wonder that Jesus' Name carries so much weight. After all, the Father once parted the clouds to proclaim that He was "well-pleased" with Jesus. (*See Matthew 3:17*)

Of course, it should be noted that the Model Prayer does not speak of the Name of Jesus, *per se*. Rather the Lord's Prayer mentions only the Name of the Father. Jesus instructs us to declare that the Father's Name is hallowed. Certainly, there is little difference between the Name of the Father and the Name of the Son, at least from our perspective. We baptize followers in both Names. (*See Matthew 28:19.*) We teach that Jesus, being a member of the Holy Trinity, is on equal footing with God the Father. (*See John 5:18, Philippians 2:6.*) Nevertheless, for reasons that will be apparent later, this distinction between the Name of the Father and the Name of the Son is of critical import to our discussion.

At this juncture, I must confess that when I discuss the Holy Trinity, every shred of logic found in the left side of my brain is set aside. It is hard—in fact, it is almost impossible—for me to comprehend how God is three parts in one. Please don't misunderstand me. I believe in the concept of the Holy Trinity. Nevertheless, I must admit that, on a purely logical level, it is problematic for me to explain. It is difficult to elucidate how the Father and the Son can simultaneously be united and yet remain separate. Even as I type this book, I feel downright silly illustrating how the Name of the Father and the Name of the Son are distinct while explaining how the Father and the Son are, in fact, one. Nevertheless, until someone comes up with a better explanation, the concept of the Holy Trinity is the best way our fragile minds can describe the infinite workings of the One True Living God.

So while offering an apology for my clumsy explanation, I will continue with my exposition.

Why do we have to pray that God's Name be hallowed if it is already the most hallowed Name in the entire universe? Assuming for the sake of this discussion that we are hallowing the Name of the Father, as opposed to the Son, how can such an infinitely hallowed Name be exalted any further?

It can't.

To illustrate my point, I direct your attention to the famed "Gettysburg Address." In November 1863, President Abraham Lincoln dedicated the Soldier's National Cemetery following the Battle of Gettysburg. Although his speech barely mentions God and has no religious purpose, President Lincoln's words can be used, by analogy, to illustrate the purpose for praying, "Hallowed be Thy Name":

But, in a larger sense, we can not dedicate — we can not consecrate — we can not hallow — this ground. The brave men, living and dead, who struggled here, have consecrated it, far above our poor power to add or detract. The world will little note, nor long remember what we say here, but it can never forget what they did here. It is for us the living, rather, to be dedicated here to the unfinished work which they who fought here have thus far so nobly advanced.⁴

In the final analysis, there is nothing—absolutely nothing—that we can do to hallow the Name of God the Father. God, Himself, has consecrated His own Name "far above our poor power to add or detract." In the same way Lincoln felt powerless to honor the sacrifice of the soldiers who had fought at Gettysburg, so should we feel incapable of giving glory to God's Name. Rather, when we contemplate the wonder of His Name, we should feel a renewed sense of dedication to the task that God has placed before us.

Just as President Lincoln felt so humbled that he dedicated himself all the more to accomplishing the task of preserving the Union, so should we feel a greater motivation to fulfill God's Plan when we consider His exalted reputation as the Creator of the Universe.

Our feeble attempts to hallow His Name serve another purpose as well.

Sir Isaac Newton stated, "For every action, there is an equal and opposite reaction."⁵ To illustrate, if a person pushes against a brick wall, the wall will not move forward; instead, the person will move backward. If a person places his foot on the ground and pushes down with all of his weight, the ground will not move, but he will stand up. Every time we apply force to an immovable object, an equivalent force will push us away from the object.

In like manner, if we exalt the Name of the Father, His Name will not be raised in the slightest. His reputation is just as immovable as a skyscraper or the ground. There is nothing that we can do to add value to His Name. Rather, as we proclaim the holiness of His Name, the relative value of our names will diminish—at least in our own eyes, if no where else. As we praise the Name of the Father, as we attempt to lift an already vaulted Name to even higher heights, we shall push ourselves further into the ground. As we attempt to exalt the reputation of God Almighty, we shall diminish our own reputations in the process. In effect, when we pray, "Hallowed by Thy Name," we are proclaiming the very desecration of our own names.

Just look at the story of King David in II Samuel 6:16, 20-23 (with emphasis added):

And as the ark of the LORD came into the city of David, Michal Saul's daughter looked through a window, and saw king David leaping and dancing

before the LORD; and she despised him in her heart.
(v. 16)

Then David returned to bless his household. And Michal the daughter of Saul came out to meet David, and said, How glorious was the king of Israel to-day, who uncovered himself to-day in the eyes of the handmaids of his servants, as one of the vain fellows shamelessly uncovereth himself! (v. 20)

And David said unto Michal, It was before the LORD, which chose me before thy father, and before all his house, to appoint me ruler over the people of the LORD, over Israel: therefore will I play before the LORD. (v. 21)

And I will yet be more vile than thus, and will be base in mine own sight: and of the maidservants which thou hast spoken of, of them shall I be had in honour. (v. 22)

Therefore Michal the daughter of Saul had no child unto the day of her death. (v. 23)

David recognized that true worship will cause a person to become base in his own sight. As David danced before the Lord, as he publicly exalted the Name of God in singing and shouting, David recognized that his actions were unbecoming of a victorious king. So did his wife, Michal, who dressed him down for acting like such a fool. However, David realized that it is necessary for a successful person to get off his high horse from time to time. As his son would

later write, “Pride goeth before destruction, and an haughty spirit before a fall.” (Proverbs 16:18)

By the way, did you notice that Michal stopped having children after this point? Whether this infertility was caused by some acute physiological malady, or whether it was the result of David, perhaps, losing his affection, I do not know. Whatever the reason, infertility was a sign of shame for women in the Old Testament. Thus, by being ashamed of her husband’s desire to praise God in an undignified manner, Michal suffered additional shame for the rest of her life. But I digress.

It is impossible, absolutely impossible, for us to pray for God’s Name to be hallowed if we desire for our names to be exalted in the process. We cannot pray for God’s Name to be hallowed if we want to be star of the show. We cannot pray for God’s Name to be hallowed as long as we desire to enhance our own respective reputations in the process.

In order to pray for God’s Name—for God’s reputation—to be hallowed, we must be willing for our names—for our reputations—to diminish. We must be willing to take one for the team. If necessary, we must permit our reputations to be run through the mud if it will ultimately bring glory to the Name of the Father.

Look closely at Philippians 2:5-8:

Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus: (v. 5)

Who, being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God: (v. 6)

But made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant, and was made in the likeness of men: (v. 7)

And being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself, and became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross. (v. 8)

Absolutely, positively, and without exception, we must check our egos at the door if we intend to live the Model Prayer. If we intend to walk the “Godly Path of Least Resistance,” we must humble ourselves before the Lord. “God resisteth the proud, and giveth grace to the humble.” (I Peter 5:5)

We must place zero value in our reputations. Even if we think that we deserve to be in charge, even if we sincerely believe that we are the greatest people in town, we must each take on the mantle of a servant and lay our reputations at the door. Instead of deriving pride from our own standing—from our own successes—we must derive our value from the reputation of Jesus. Like John the Baptist, our prayer must be for Jesus’ stature to increase, and for our reputations to decrease. (*See* John 3:30)

Naturally, this is a challenging task. Praying for the reputation of a God we cannot see to increase, even at the expense of our own reputations, is quite difficult. None of us wishes to suffer rejection. All of us, to some degree or another, wish to be welcomed wherever we go. We all want to be loved. We all want loving favor. We all know that loving favor is somehow tied to the value of our respective reputations. If more people celebrate our achievements, then more people will like us. If more people like us, then we will enjoy more benefits in life. This seems axiomatic, really.

However, as we strive to enhance our reputations, as we attempt to earn loving favor from other flawed human beings, we will miss similar opportunities to humble ourselves before the Lord. We will miss the opportunities to receive loving favor (or grace) from God. While an exalted reputation may

earn loving favor from man, our humility attracts the loving favor (or grace) of God.

The grace of God is essential for our salvation. It is essential for our provision. It is essential for our deliverance. It is essential for our protection. The grace of God will provide everything we could possibly need to fulfill God's Plan for our lives. Therefore, we must seek after the grace of God, even at the expense of our own reputations. Otherwise, we may receive loving favor from the world, but still fail to receive what we really need from God.

Now, please don't misunderstand me. In a perfect world, the words *integrity* and *reputation* would be synonymous. In a perfect world, a person of integrity would necessarily possess a good reputation; conversely, a person of ill repute would invariably be of poor character. Ours, however, is not a perfect world. Sometimes the bad guys are respected and the good guys are maligned.

As strange as it may seem, people have been known to lie and cheat in order to protect their standing in the community—and with much success, I might add. Accordingly, if we are so focused upon protecting our reputations, as opposed to protecting our integrity, we may seek after the vainglory that comes through pride instead of searching for the loving favor that comes through humility.

Humility is a trait that is missing among our leaders, both in the Church and in our society-at-large. The most successful people, sometimes even in Christendom, are hardly ever humble. There is a reason for this, I suppose. Conventional wisdom teaches that a prospective leader cannot do any good for his organization unless he develops a following. To develop a following, he must have "positive name recognition." To create name recognition, he must seek after publicity. To create publicity, he must perform some extraordinary feat that sets him apart from other prospective leaders.

To some extent, this is all true, even in the Church. How does one build a ministry without convincing people to offer their support—whether by praying or by giving or by simply showing up to hear the minister speak? Accordingly, how does a minister convince people to support his ministry (at the relative expense of other ministries that could otherwise be supported) without having some positive name recognition?

Furthermore, how does a minister develop name recognition without enjoying some measure of good publicity? Finally, how does a minister create good publicity without accomplishing some feat (e.g., earning a degree in theology, or writing a book, or healing a sick person through prayer)? Certainly, if one intends to build a ministry, an audience is required.

With that said, I think we may have the cart before the horse. Perhaps we have become so consumed with building our own ministries that we have forgotten how to be ministers.

Several years after he resigned from office in disgrace, Richard Nixon became somewhat of an elder statesman. From the time he left office to the very month before he died, he wrote numerous books. In one such volume, Mr. Nixon offers an observation that might have spared him a great deal of heartache if he had adhered to it earlier in his career: “What separates the men from the boys in politics,” he notes, “is that the boys seek office to *be* somebody and the men seek office to *do* something.”⁶

Although President Nixon was referring to politics, I nevertheless believe that the same could be said about any field of public endeavor—especially Christian ministry.

A great leader will strive toward a goal simply because the endeavor is lofty in its own right. Conversely, the weak leader will attempt a task only because he wants to derive greatness from such a stunning accomplishment.

Applying this to the life of a Christian, a leader who is secure in the greatness—in the loving favor and grace—that he has derived from Jesus Christ will never derive value from personal achievement. On the contrary, his accomplishments will derive their worth from the leader's relationship with God. In fact, the leader will be so secure in the loving favor of God that he will not glory in his successes, but rather in his weaknesses. (*See* II Corinthians 12:9)

Look at Jesus. Think of all the phenomenal things that He did. He healed countless thousands. He raised the dead. He cast out demonic spirits. He had more power in His pinky finger than the combined power of the Pharisees and the Sadducees. Yet, He never gloried in His own accomplishments.

After healing people, He often instructed them to keep their miracles a secret. (*See, e.g.,* Matthew 8:4; Mark 7:36; Luke 5:14, 8:56.) When His fame grew to the point where He became a celebrated rabbi, He would withdraw to the wilderness and pray. (*See* Luke 5:15-16.) In fact, Jesus' tendency to hide from publicity is evidenced by the reaction of His brothers in John 7:3-4:

His brethren therefore said unto him, Depart hence, and go into Judaea, that thy disciples also may see the works that thou doest. (v. 3)

For there is no man that doeth any thing in secret, and he himself seeketh to be known openly. If thou do these things, shew thyself to the world. (v. 4)

Insomuch as it was possible, Jesus made a point of keeping Himself out of the picture. Granted, it was impossible for Jesus to stay completely out of the public eye, but it didn't stop Him from trying. The more He would run from fame, the more fame would run to Him.

Paul puts it this way in Philippians 2:8-11:

And being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself, and became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross. (v. 8)

Wherefore God also hath highly exalted him, and given him a name which is above every name: (v. 9)

That at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of things in heaven, and things in earth, and things under the earth; (v. 10)

And that every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father. (v. 11)

Even on those occasions when Jesus was exalted, He would subsequently humble Himself even further. For example, the pinnacle of Jesus' earthly glory was His triumphal entry into Jerusalem. He rode on a colt that no one had ever ridden, and He accepted the praises that were reserved only for the Messiah. (*See* Matthew 21:1-11.) Yet, barely a week later, He willingly suffered the most ignominious death known to man—death on the Roman cross.

This is our example. We must humble ourselves if we expect the power and glory of God to work through our lives. How do we do this? We do so by exalting the Name of the Father, even to the detriment of our own respective names.

Each of us must reach a point in our respective walks where we value the reputation of the Father more than we value our own reputations.

In the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus said, "Let your light so shine before men, that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father which is in heaven." (Matthew 5:16.) Oddly enough, in the very same discourse, Jesus cautioned,

“Take heed that ye do not your alms before men, to be seen of them: otherwise ye have no reward of your Father which is in heaven.” (Matthew 6:1)

On the one hand, our works should be seen by men so that God will be glorified. On the other hand, we are to do our giving in secret. Seems peculiar, doesn’t it?

From these passages, we may glean that Jesus understood how good works, by their very nature, attract attention. No matter how much He tried, He could not escape the spectacle of His works. Nevertheless, Jesus taught that we should not detract from the manifestation of God’s Power by bringing unnecessary attention to ourselves. In other words, we should do everything in our power to distance ourselves from the performance—even if it means doing the work in secret. Otherwise, people will see our good works and glorify us—and not the Father.

Even Jesus set this example when giving us the Lord’s Prayer. Although He knew that He was equal to God the Father, by virtue of His place in the Holy Trinity, He nevertheless instructed His disciples to hallow the *Father’s* Name and not *His own* Name. This is the critical distinction to which I made earlier reference. Although Jesus had every right to demand our highest praise, He chose to glorify the Father, even at the expense of His own reputation.

In the same spirit, we Christians should do everything in our power to glorify the Name of Jesus without bringing unnecessary attention to ourselves.

And so we reach the conclusion of this lesson, to wit: As we pray for God’s Name to be hallowed, we will invariably humble ourselves in the process. Indeed we will become more aware of how our reputations can never invite the grace of God into our lives. Nevertheless, as we humble ourselves—as we sincerely desire to avoid fame—we will be entrusted with the very fame that we endeavor to avoid (because God will know that it won’t go to our heads; He will know that

when the time comes to escape the crowds, we will happily return to the wilderness to seek the Father.)

Indeed, as we sincerely abandon all desire to build names for ourselves, we will obtain access to the Name of Jesus and to the loving favor that runs appurtenant thereto.

Chapter
THIRD SEMESTER:
“THY KINGDOM COME”



This chapter very well may be the most metaphysical section of this book. To draw an example from pop culture, for those readers who may be “Star Trek” fans, this section will be more akin to *The Search for Spock* than will it be to *The Wrath of Khan*. Unlike the two previous chapters, where we have explored how one should react to the manifest characteristics of our Heavenly Father (*i.e.*, His infinite love, His supreme objectivity, and His vaulted reputation), this chapter will explore the esoteric concept of the Kingdom of God and how it operates on Earth.

Before I delve into the subject of this chapter, a brief review is warranted. In the first section of the Model Prayer (“Our Father which art in Heaven”), we learned about God’s character—about how He is infinitely loving, supremely objective, and uncompromising in His principles. In the second section (“Hallowed be thy Name”), we observed that God’s Name—that His reputation—is exalted simply because His character is so lofty.

Given the progressive nature of the Lord’s Prayer, it would follow that our Heavenly Father, whose character is spotless and whose reputation is exalted, should reign supreme over His creation. In light of the mess that we have created on

Planet Earth, God is the only One with the strength of character and the positive name recognition to govern a world in such dire need as ours is. As such, it becomes necessary to examine the Kingdom of God and its coming.

The word *kingdom* is really the combination of two words, *king* and *dominion*. A kingdom is, by definition, the dominion of a king. It is where a king exercises complete control. It is where the King dominates everyone—and everything—else.

Naturally a king may not exercise authority outside of his dominion, *i.e.*, outside of his own kingdom. A king's authority is restricted by the boundaries of his territory. If a king wishes to exercise authority over a different realm, he must use military might or diplomatic means to expand his influence over the land in question. Once the king expands his dominion to cover the new region, he may then exert his will over the new realm even as he would over his own territory.

It follows then that a king's dominion is made manifest by his power. A person who lacks power to control others could hardly be deemed a king or queen. Granted, there are some countries, like the United Kingdom, where the monarch is merely a figurehead and the elected leaders call the shots. However, even in these places, the Crown is still considered the wellspring of power.

In the United Kingdom, for example, the monarch still must give “royal assent” to an act of Parliament before it becomes law. Although royal assent is pretty much a formality, the fact that a proposed law still must have the Crown's approval nevertheless proves that power in the United Kingdom is derived from the monarch.⁷ Likewise, only the Queen “can summon Parliament, and prorogue (discontinue without dissolving it) or dissolve it.”⁸ Practically speaking, if the Queen wanted to send members of Parliament home—and keep them there—at least in theory, she could. Lastly,

even though members of the House of Commons select the Prime Minister, who acts as the Head of Government, the monarch reserves the right to appoint the Prime Minister herself.⁹ So while Her Majesty's powers may be limited by certain Acts of Parliament, if she had a mind to, she could take much of this power back.

Of course, in the days of Christ, there was no such thing as a "constitutional monarchy." Back then, a king had absolute power over his subjects. Indeed, there was no doubt who was in control of the kingdom. If the king wanted to kill a person, he could. If a king wanted to rob his subjects of their lands, no one could stop him. *Rex lex* (i.e., "the king is law") was the order of the day. The king had power, and he would use it to dominate his subjects.

Jesus compared how this domineering leadership style differs from His approach to leadership as stated in Matthew 20:25-28:

Ye know that the princes of the Gentiles exercise dominion over them, and they that are great exercise authority upon them. (v. 25)

But it shall not be so among you: but whosoever will be great among you, let him be your minister; (v. 26)

and whosoever will be chief among you, let him be your servant: (v. 27)

Even as the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many. (v. 28)

According to the website www.blueletterbible.org and the *Strong's Concordance*, the phrase "thy kingdom come,"

is translated from the Greek “*sou basileia erchomai*.”¹⁰ The word *erchomai* (or “come”) is in the second aorist tense, active voice, and imperative mood.¹¹

The aorist tense simply means that “the concept of the verb is considered without regard for past, present, or future time.”¹² In other words, our prayer does not consider whether the Kingdom of God did come, is coming, or will come. Rather, the Model Prayer is more concerned about the continued advancement of the Kingdom and not necessarily its completed arrival.¹³

The active voice means that the Kingdom is the subject and “to come” is the verb. The imperative mood means that we are actively commanding the Kingdom of God to come.¹⁴ It is not a request, “but an absolute command requiring full obedience on the part of all hearers.”¹⁵ In the case of the Model Prayer, we are actually commanding the Kingdom of God to come.

In light of tense, voice and mood of *erchomai*, we may surmise that when we pray, “Thy Kingdom come,” we are commanding the Kingdom of God to move, not necessarily to arrive at a particular destination at a particular time, but simply to move in our general direction.

Put another way, when we pray, “Thy Kingdom come,” we are concerned about the Kingdom’s expansion, not necessarily the end result of its growth. In the same way that people sometimes desire money simply for the sake of having it, we should pray for the Kingdom of God to come simply because we desire its expansion.

(I said this chapter would be esoteric.)

In light of Jesus’ reluctance to act like a Gentile king, and given His command that we should pray for God’s Kingdom to come, it would seem that the movement of God’s Kingdom depends exclusively upon our prayers. In stark contrast to the *modus operandi* of the Roman emperors who would unilaterally apply force to conquer new territory, the Kingdom

of God will not expand *sua sponte* (i.e., on its own). The Kingdom of God will only come when we actively pray for it to come.

The words *basileia* and *erchomai* (or “kingdom” and “come”) are found together only fourteen times in the New Testament.¹⁶ Of these fourteen verses, only seven relate to the coming of the Kingdom of God or of Jesus coming into His kingdom. These seven passages are quoted below:

Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven. (Matthew 6:10)

Verily I say unto you, There be some standing here, which shall not taste of death, till they see the Son of man coming in his kingdom. (Matthew 16:28)

And he said unto them, Verily I say unto you, That there be some of them that stand here, which shall not taste of death, till they have seen the kingdom of God come with power. (Mark 9:1)

And he said unto them, When ye pray, say, Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done, as in heaven, so in earth. (Luke 11:2)

And when he was demanded of the Pharisees, when the kingdom of God should come, he answered them and said, The kingdom of God cometh not with observation: Neither shall they say, Lo here! or, lo there! for, behold, the kingdom of God is within you. (Luke 17:20-21)

For I say unto you, I will not drink of the fruit of the vine, until the kingdom of God shall come. (Luke 22:18)

And he said unto Jesus, Lord, remember me when thou comest into thy kingdom. (Luke 23:42)

Notice from the above-listed passages how the Kingdom of God comes. In Luke 17:20-21, we are instructed that the Kingdom of God does not come with “observation” (or Greek *paratērēsis*).¹⁷ We will not be able to see the Kingdom of God as it comes because it arrives in a person’s heart. However, in Mark 9:1, Jesus explained that some people who were alive back then would not die until they had “seen” (or Greek *eidon*)¹⁸ the Kingdom of God come with power.

In Luke 17:20-21, Jesus says that the coming of the Kingdom of God would be invisible. Yet in Mark 9:1, Jesus said that some people would actually see the Kingdom of God come in power. This seems contradictory, does it not?

Not quite! Although the Greek word *paratērēsis* refers to visual observation, *eidon*, on the other hand, does not relate exclusively to human sight. According to *Strong’s Concordance*, *eidon* means, among other things, “to experience any state or condition.”¹⁹ Thus, while a blind man could never observe (“*paratērēsis*”) the midday sun, he could nevertheless experience (“*eidon*”) the sun’s heat. Regardless, such a blind man would know that the sun is shining.

In Mark 9:1, Jesus was most likely stating that some people who were alive then would *experience* the coming of the Kingdom of God as they felt the Holy Spirit move in their lives or as they witnessed the Holy Spirit work in the lives of others. Although such persons would not “see” the proverbial gates of God’s Kingdom expand, nor would they “see” God sitting on His Throne, nor would they even “see” the Holy Spirit—they would nevertheless perceive the

coming of God's Kingdom as they witnessed the effects of His Power firsthand.

Thayer's Lexicon confirms this interpretation. Therein, *erchomai* is described as a metaphor for "Christ's invisible return from Heaven, *i.e.*, of the power of which through the Holy Spirit he will exert in the souls of his disciples."²⁰ Thus, when we pray, "Thy Kingdom come," we are in effect praying for God to pour more of His Power into our lives.

Now we must examine how Jesus equated the coming of the Kingdom of God with the coming of the Son of Man in His Kingdom. In Mark 9:1, Jesus said that some people would not taste death until they had seen (*eidon*) the Kingdom of God come (*erchomai*) with power. Yet, in Matthew 16:28, Jesus said that some people would not taste death until they had seen (*eidon*) the Son of Man come (*erchomai*) into His Kingdom.

We know that in both passages, Jesus is referring to the same event because the verses preceding each passage (*i.e.*, Matthew 16:27 and Mark 8:38) speak of Christ coming (*erchomai*) in the glory of the Father with the holy angels. Moreover, both passages use precisely the same Greek phraseology (*tis histemi hode hostis geuomai ou me geuomai thanatos*).²¹ Given the obvious similarities between the passages, by inductive reasoning, we may conclude that Christ's coming into His Kingdom is synonymous with God's Kingdom coming.

Certainly, this equation appears peculiar. In Mark 9:1, the Kingdom of God is the subject, and it is coming. In Matthew 16:28, Jesus is the subject, and He is coming into His Kingdom. In Mark 9:1, it would appear that the Kingdom is moving, but in Matthew 16:28, it would appear that the Kingdom is static, while the King is moving.

The key to understanding this dichotomy is found in Luke 23:42-43. Here, the penitent thief asked Jesus to remember

him when Jesus comes into His Kingdom. Jesus replied, “To day shalt thou be with me in paradise.”

Pay careful attention to both the question and the answer. The thief asked to be with Jesus when He entered into His Kingdom. Jesus replied by saying that the thief would be with Jesus that very day in Paradise. By answering the thief’s question in this manner, Jesus associated His death with His coming into His Kingdom. Had this not been His intention, Jesus’ answer would have been non-responsive to the thief’s question. Indeed, Jesus could have answered the question with a simple “yes” or “no.” Instead, He answered with a statement, and we may reasonably infer that such statement was an appropriate response to the request.

After Jesus died on the cross, on that very day, He entered into Paradise with the penitent thief. No, Jesus didn’t physically ascend into Heaven as He would later do after the Resurrection, but He did enter into Paradise on the day He died. When Jesus entered Paradise, by virtue of His statement to the thief, we know that He also came (*erchomai*) into His Kingdom. Furthermore, by virtue of how the coming (*erchomai*) of Jesus into His Kingdom equates with the coming (*erchomai*) of God’s Kingdom to Earth, we may deduce that God’s Kingdom came when Jesus entered Paradise.

The above exegesis is confirmed by the events that transpired following the death of Jesus. Matthew 27:50-54 describes the unusual phenomena that occurred that afternoon:

Jesus, when he had cried again with a loud voice,
yielded up the ghost. (v. 50)

And, behold, the veil of the temple was rent in twain
from the top to the bottom; and the earth did quake,
and the rocks rent; (v. 51)

And the graves were opened; and many bodies of the saints which slept arose, (v. 52)

And came out of the graves after his resurrection, and went into the holy city, and appeared unto many. (v. 53)

Now when the centurion, and they that were with him, watching Jesus, saw the earthquake, and those things that were done, they feared greatly, saying, Truly this was the Son of God. (v. 54)

When Jesus died on the cross, the veil of the temple was torn. Now to comprehend the significance of this event, one must understand that the veil separated humanity from the Holy of Holies, which is the one place on Earth where God's Presence was found in full measure. Only the High Priest could enter the Holy of Holies, and even then he had to wear a rope around his waist with an attached bell.²² Other priests would hold the rope from behind the veil. If the High Priest did something incorrect, God would strike him dead, and of course, the bell would stop ringing. Once the bell stopped ringing, the other priests would know that they needed to pull the lifeless remains of the High Priest out of the Holy Place.

The tearing of the veil signified that God's Presence would no longer be limited by the physical boundaries of the Holy of Holies. Instead, God's Presence, His Power, and by extension, His Kingdom would expand from the Jewish temple to the farthest reaches of humanity.

Put another way, when Jesus came (*erchomai*) into His Kingdom, the Kingdom of God also came (*erchomai*) to Earth. The veil was torn, graves were robbed, and the ground shook. The Jewish world experienced the Kingdom of God as it came with power that day.

Keep in mind that *erchomai* is in aorist tense; thus, there is no past, present, or future tense to describe the coming of God's Kingdom. The above discussion should not be confused with a discourse on the so-called "Rapture" or "Second Coming of Christ." For sure, the Second Coming would be the ultimate manifestation of His Kingdom coming. However, to some degree, the Kingdom of God has already come.

Throughout the world, there are Christians who love the Lord with all of their hearts, souls, minds, and strength. When the Holy Spirit speaks to them, they will obey—even if it means certain death—because they know that they are subject to a much higher authority. Because they have fully submitted to the plans and purposes of their Heavenly Father—the Ultimate Example of sacrificial love, the Supreme Arbiter of right and wrong, the only One with a perfect reputation—they can be trusted by the Holy Spirit to exercise God's delegated power and authority on this planet. And with this power, they shall cause God's Will to be done on Earth, even as it is in Heaven.

The Kingdom of God is already present in the hearts of these people. Nevertheless as they seek even more for God's Kingdom, as they pray even more for God's Kingdom to be released into the world around them, God's Power will continue to come in greater measure, and they will see the miracle-working Power of God operate in their lives. Moreover, as God's Power continues to come, so shall His Kingdom continue to come, until finally our Lord and Savior shall reveal Himself, and every knee shall bow and every tongue shall confess that He is Lord of all.²³

Think of a train. The death of Jesus on the cross is like the locomotive, blowing its smoke into the clear, blue sky. The Second Coming of Christ is like the caboose, the final car in the procession. Until the caboose is parked at its destination, the train will still be coming (unless it stops). Yet,

once we see the locomotive arrive at the station, never mind that the caboose is still a mile away, we will say that the train has come. Likewise, from the time of Jesus' death until now, we have seen railcar after railcar pass before us. We have seen movement after movement of the Holy Spirit. Each movement of the Holy Spirit—each railcar of the train—is further proof that the Kingdom of God has come and is still coming.²⁴

For the purposes of our discussion, we must glean the greater motivation for praying “Thy Kingdom come.” Unless we have access to the Kingdom of God, we may not have access to the Power of God. If we cannot access the Power of God, how then can our prayers be answered? Even if we are praying for that which is God's Will, our Lord must still apply His Power to the circumstance in order to affect change.

This is why it becomes imperative for people to make Jesus Christ the Lord of their lives. Unless He is our king, unless we are submitted to His authority, what right do we have to be a part of His kingdom? We must be citizens of the Kingdom of God, naturalized by the Blood of Jesus, in order to access the power that runs appurtenant to our Lord's Dominion.

Simply saying that Jesus is our king is not enough. Simply calling Him “Lord” is insufficient. We must do the will of the Father in order to enter His Kingdom. (*See* Matthew 7:21.) Our righteousness must exceed that of the Pharisees. (*See* Matthew 5:20.) In other words, our character must reflect our total submission to God's Plan for our lives.

The Apostle Paul describes this transformation in I Corinthians 6:9-11:

Know ye not that the unrighteous shall not inherit the kingdom of God? Be not deceived: neither fornica-

tors, nor idolaters, nor adulterers, nor effeminate, nor abusers of themselves with mankind, (v. 9)

Nor thieves, nor covetous, nor drunkards, nor revilers, nor extortioners, shall inherit the kingdom of God. (v. 10)

And such were some of you: but ye are washed, but ye are sanctified, but ye are justified in the name of the Lord Jesus, and by the Spirit of our God. (v. 11)

Our character—our obedience to God is *prima facie* evidence of whether Jesus Christ is truly Lord of our lives. If He is Lord of one's life—if the Kingdom of God has come into a person's heart—then such a one will live his life in accordance with Kingdom principles. Conversely, if Christ is not truly Lord of a person's life, then he will not embrace the Kingdom of God, nor will he enjoy access to the Power of God; and without God's Power, such a one will never traverse the Godly Path of Least Resistance.

If I were to vacuum my room, I would first need to plug my vacuum cleaner into a wall receptacle; otherwise, the machine would not operate, no matter how much I might will for it to work. Likewise, if I wanted God to answer my prayers, God's Power must be connected to my situation. In order for God's Power to come, God's Kingdom must come. In order for God's Kingdom to come, I must acknowledge that God is my Heavenly Father (*i.e.*, that He is perfectly loving, supremely objective, and uncompromising in His principles). I must then demonstrate my willingness to advance God's reputation, even at the expense of my own. Finally, I must seek God's Kingdom as if my very life depended on it.

Chapter
FOURTH SEMESTER:
“THY WILL BE DONE IN EARTH,
AS IT IS IN HEAVEN.”



H Having concluded our discourse on the third section of the Lord's Prayer ("Thy Kingdom come"), we should realize by now that God's Kingdom ought to come because God is the only Being with the strength of character ("Our Father which art in Heaven") and the exalted reputation ("Hallowed be Thy Name") necessary to assume dominion over the universe. It follows, then, that if only God should have absolute authority, then only God should have absolute power.

Although it is common parlance to use the words *power* and *authority* interchangeably, the fact is they are not the same. *Power* implies ability, while *authority* denotes right. A person with power *can* do something. A person with authority *may* do something.

Take driving a car, for example. A person with a suspended driver's license is prohibited from operating a vehicle on a public roadway. Be that as it may, this lack of authority doesn't mean that he is incapable of driving a car; such a one will still have the power to drive for as long as he has access to a vehicle. On the other hand, another person

may have a valid driver's license, but unless he has access to transportation, the driver's license is of little use.

Simply put, in order to accomplish a particular task, a person should have not only the power to act, but the authority to act as well.

With respect to God, we know that He has all authority. (*See* Matthew 28:18.) He is, after all, a sovereign Being. Likewise, we know that He is all-powerful. Certainly, if God can create matter by speaking it into existence, then He should have no problem exerting the force necessary to achieve His objectives. However, as we have learned in the last chapter, for God's Power to be of any use to us, we must first seek after His Kingdom. Put another way, we must access His Power by submitting to His authority.

This makes sense when we think about it. Even if we were to have unfettered access to God's Power, it would still be God's Power and not ours. So, if we are going to utilize God's Power, we must play by His rules. We must use His Power according to His Will, not according to ours.

Naturally, this raises an interesting question: What is the purpose for His Power? In other words, if God's Kingdom were advanced to the infinite degree, where every person loved and obeyed God and submitted to His authority, what would the world look like?

In a word: Heaven.

In the Lord's Prayer, we are asking God to advance His Kingdom, and then to use the power of the Kingdom to transform Earth into a version of Heaven. Therefore, if we want to see the final result of what Earth would be like if God were in complete control, all we need to do is catch a glimpse of Heaven.

Revelation 21 teaches that at the end of time, God will create a new Heaven and a new Earth. Now, I will readily admit that I do not understand why God would create a new Heaven. Be that as it may, from how He describes the place,

we may readily ascertain that if He were to have His way on Earth like He plans to do in Heaven, then what a place Earth would be! Verse 4 sums it up:

And God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain: for the former things are passed away.

When it all boils down, Heaven is God's dream for humanity. Whenever we pray the Model Prayer, this is where we are headed. This is why Jesus died such an ignominious death: (1) so that those who derive their righteousness from Him; (2) so that those who seek the loving favor that comes from having God's Name written on their hearts; (3) so that those who submit to the Lordship of Christ—so that these people will one day live with Him in a world free from sorrow, pain and death.

However, if this is truly God's Plan, then why doesn't He simply take control of the world and fix all of our problems right now? Why does He need for us to pray for His Will to be done on Earth even as it is in Heaven?

To answer these questions, we must revisit the lessons of Chapter One. We must recognize that God is a Heavenly Father who is supremely objective. Even though He loves us enough that He sent His only Son to die for our sins, He is not blinded by His love to the point where He would compromise His principles in order to save our skins. He loves humanity, but He also loves truth.

Although God's desire to preserve sinful humanity and His desire for a spotless people may seem diametrically opposite, He has reconciled the two by way of Christ's sacrifice. God may now save the world without sacrificing His values, provided that the persons who are being saved embrace His holiness and renounce their rebellious ways. Yes, He could

force human beings into submission, but what would be the utility in that? If God had wanted robots, He would have created them.

God has always invited mankind's participation. Back in the Garden, He allowed Adam to name all of the animals. (*See* Genesis 2:19-20.) Although God could have assigned names Himself, He didn't. His Will was to allow Adam to use his imagination to impact the world around him. Likewise, when God gave Adam and Eve dominion over every living creature on the Earth (*see* Genesis 1:28), He understood that they might screw-up and that the world would be shaped accordingly. Indeed, God appreciated the consequences of free will. He still does.

I learned a valuable lesson about consequences during my final year of law school. Back then, I had the pleasure of being instructed by John Ashcroft, the former Attorney General of the United States. Since I attended a religious law school (Regent University School of Law), we had devotionals at the beginning of each class period. The first time I heard General Ashcroft speak in person, he gave a devotional about living a life of meaning. I will never forget one particular thing he said: "A life without consequence is a life without meaning."

If there are no negative repercussions to our mistakes, the Attorney General observed, then how could we ever expect for any benefits to result from our successes? Since God wants our lives to have meaning—since God wants our lives to advance His Kingdom and to execute His Plan—the Attorney General concluded that we *must* reap what we sow.

In contemplation of General Ashcroft's devotional, I thought of a tire. For a tire to roll—for a tire to move—it must have traction. It must have something to grab. When a tire spins on an icy surface, it will likely hydroplane. On the

other hand, when a tire rotates on dry asphalt, it will move with no problem. What's the difference? Friction is.

Friction is necessary for forward motion in physics. In like manner, consequences are requisite for advancement in life.

As Sir Isaac Newton observed, "For every action, there is an equal and opposite reaction."²⁵ If the ground didn't push the tire after the tire pushed the ground, the tire wouldn't go anywhere. Along these lines, if our actions didn't cause reactions, such actions would be meaningless. Like a tire spinning in the sand, our lives would be of little use to God or even to ourselves if we did not have to experience the consequences of our decisions.

As General Ashcroft noted, God is a God of meaning. When He acts, He expects a corresponding reaction. When He said, "Let there be light," He expected for light to come into being. (See Genesis 1:3.) When Jesus spoke to the fig tree, He expected for it to wither. (See Mark 11:20-23.) When Jesus spoke to the raging wind, He expected for it to calm. (See Mark 4:39.) When Jesus commanded devils to leave those possessed, He expected the demons to leave. (See, e.g., Matthew 9:32, 12:22, 15:22.) Most importantly, when Jesus died on the cross, He expected to draw all men unto Him. (See John 12:32.) Clearly, when God operates, He expects for His actions to produce results. Wouldn't you?

The same holds true when He operates through us. As we submit more to the authority of His Kingdom, God will entrust us with more of His Power. As we have more of His Power, we will be able to perform "greater works" than Jesus did. (See John 14:12.)

Now what is a "work"? It is an object's reaction to the force that we have applied.

As we apply the force of God's Power upon the world around us, the world will change into a place quite similar to Heaven itself. As we exercise God's Power, we will see the

positive consequences of our actions on the world around us.

Perhaps this is why faith moves mountains while other Godly characteristics will not. (*See* Mark 11:22-24.) Faith is the ultimate expression of expectancy. A person who walks in faith is one who truly understands that life has consequences. A person of faith knows full well that every decision one makes affects not only the person making it, but others as well. That is why a person who is full of faith is, by definition, a *faithful* person.

Ever mindful of the consequences of power that is improperly used, the person of faith will strive to remain true to God's Plan and Purpose. The faithful servant knows that, in the Kingdom of Heaven, the ends do not always justify the means. Substantively, God may desire for Earth to become a Heavenly outpost. However, God understands that there is an appropriate procedure to achieve this end.

For example, even though it is God's Will that no person should perish, the plan of salvation still demands repentance. (*See* II Peter 3:9.) Likewise, even though Jesus performed numerous supernatural healings while He walked the Earth, He did not perform "mighty works" in His hometown because the people had unbelief. (*See* Mark 6:5.)

Just as God will not entrust the gift of salvation with a person who refuses to repent (*i.e.*, to submit to the laws of His Kingdom), neither will He entrust supernatural power to an unfaithful person. Before He will give His Anointing to a person, God must be satisfied that such a one will use this power to advance God's Plan and not the person's plan.

God's Anointing is like a company asset that cannot be used for the employee's personal business. Although, metaphorically speaking, we can expect to be compensated for our "services" (as we will learn in the next chapter), we should always remember that God's Power belongs to God, and first and foremost, it should be used for His benefit and

enjoyment. We are to advance “our Father’s business,” and not our own. (*See* Luke 2:49.)

Throughout His ministry, Jesus used parables about natural phenomena to illustrate the workings of God’s Kingdom. The Kingdom of Heaven has been likened to, among other things, wheat and tares (Matthew 13:24), a grain of mustard seed (Matthew 13:31), and leaven in meal (Matthew 13:33). Following this pattern, I will now illustrate just how important faithfulness to God’s Plan is if we intend to exercise His Power.

Pay special attention to Mark 11:20-24. It reads (with emphasis added):

And in the morning, as they passed by, they saw the fig tree dried up from the roots. (v. 20)

And Peter calling to remembrance saith unto him, Master, behold, the fig tree which thou cursedst is withered away. (v. 21)

And Jesus answering saith unto them, Have faith in God. (v. 22)

For verily I say unto you, That whosoever shall say unto this mountain, Be thou removed, and be thou cast into the sea; and shall not doubt in his heart, but shall believe that those things which he saith shall come to pass; he shall have whatsoever he saith. (v. 23)

Therefore I say unto you, What things soever ye desire, when ye pray, believe that ye receive them, and ye shall have them. (v. 24)

Now compare the above text with Matthew 17:19-20. It reads, with emphasis added:

Then came the disciples to Jesus apart, and said, Why could not we cast him out? (v. 19)

And Jesus said unto them, Because of your unbelief: for verily I say unto you, If ye have faith as a grain of mustard seed, ye shall say unto this mountain, Remove hence to yonder place; and it shall remove; and nothing shall be impossible unto you. (v. 20)

It should be noted that these are not parallel passages. Matthew and Mark are not referring to the same conversation between Jesus and His disciples. Nevertheless, we may still juxtapose the two passages because they reference the same phenomenon, namely, the use of faith to move a mountain.

Let's step back from this passage for just a moment and look at human history. Put aside everything you have heard from travelling evangelists or television preachers and simply look at recorded human history. Since Jesus spoke these words nearly two millennia ago, has there ever been a *documented* and *corroborated* instance of a person moving a mountain simply by speaking to it? (Again, disregard what any preacher has told you. Pull out your encyclopedia on this one.)

Since the actual number of confirmed mountain-moving declarations have been scarce (if there have been any at all), it would be easy to surmise, as most Christians have, that Jesus was speaking figuratively and not literally. For most of my life, I believed the same way. This changed, however, when I began to juxtapose the above passages against that which we have learned from, of all things, science.

(A word of warning: I am about to discuss a complicated principle of physics. It may seem boring at first. It may even

seem to have little relevance to this discussion. However, if you bear with me, you will truly be amazed. I promise you.)

In the early twentieth century, Albert Einstein came up with the Theory of Relativity. Now, I won't go into a diatribe about Einsteinian physics. Countless volumes have been written on the subject, so the world doesn't need another explanation about how light and time and mass and energy are intertwined. However, there is one aspect to this theory that is relevant to our discourse, namely, Einstein's famed equation, $E=mc^2$.

Einstein theorized that matter (*i.e.*, solid, liquid, or gas) could be converted into energy. Now, he wasn't talking about simply throwing a log into the fire. Although a fire would certainly release energy (*i.e.*, light and heat), such a reaction would merely change the chemical characteristics of that piece of wood, transforming the log into ash. No, Einstein wasn't talking about chemical changes to matter. Instead, Einstein reasoned that if we could split the atoms of a piece of matter (such as a radioactive substance), then we could release a mind-blowing amount of energy.²⁶

In effect, Einstein came up with the science behind the nuclear bomb.

Now, where the above formula becomes important is in the quantification of energy. Energy ("E") equals mass ("m") times the speed of light ("c") squared ("²"). According to this formula, we can determine the amount of energy contained in an object simply by measuring its mass. Once we have the mass of the object, we can calculate the amount of energy by multiplying the mass by the speed of light squared.

Think of any substance. It doesn't matter what it is. It could be any solid, liquid or gas. The only thing important is the amount of the substance. For illustration purposes, I shall refer to something that is very common: a simple packet

of sugar with the mass of one gram. Table 1 computes the amount of energy contained therein:

Mass (<i>metric grams</i>)	1
Mass (<i>British slugs</i>)	0.0000685217658568
Speed of Light (<i>ft/sec</i>)	983,571,056
Speed of Light Squared (<i>ft²/sec²</i>)	967,412,022,200,955,000
Energy (<i>slugs*ft²/sec²</i>) or (<i>ft*lbs</i>)	66,288,780,072,307

Table 1

A gram is equal to 0.0000685217658568 slugs.²⁷ (A slug is the British unit for mass; in Earth's gravity, a slug weighs about 32 pounds.²⁸) The speed of light is estimated at 983,571,056 feet per second.²⁹ Thus, the speed of light squared (*i.e.*, the speed of light times itself) would approximate 967,412,022,200,955,000 feet squared per second squared.

Now, take this number and multiply it by 0.0000685217658568 slugs. By doing so, one will find that a packet of sugar contains enough energy to perform 66,288,780,072,307 foot-pounds worth of work.

That's a big number, I know, but what is its significance? Well, by definition, a foot-pound is the amount of energy necessary to move an object weighing one pound a distance

of one foot.³⁰ Accordingly, 66,288,780,072,307 foot-pounds would be enough energy to move an object weighing 66,288,780,072,307 pounds a distance of one foot; likewise, it is enough energy to move a one-pound object a distance of 66,288,780,072,307 feet.

Let's put a face to this picture. The Washington Monument weighs 90,854 tons (or 181,708,000 pounds).³¹ Since 66,288,780,072,307 foot-pounds divided by 181,708,000 pounds equals 364,809 feet, there is enough energy stored in a packet of sugar to move the Washington Monument 364,809 feet (or 69 miles). That's enough energy to move it from its base behind the White House to Hagerstown, Maryland.

Isn't it amazing! Within something as small as a packet of sugar, God has stored enough energy to move something as massive as the Washington Monument almost as far as the Pennsylvania state line.

Now, as a practical matter, it would be virtually impossible to convert a gram of sugar into nuclear energy since the atoms comprising a sugar molecule are too stable to split. To my knowledge, scientists are capable of only splitting the atoms of radioactive substances, such as uranium, plutonium, and the like. Nevertheless, even though the nuclear energy contained within a packet of sugar—or any other non-radioactive substance—may be difficult to release, such energy is indeed present. But I digress.

Let's examine Matthew 17:20 one more time:

And Jesus said unto them, Because of your unbelief: for verily I say unto you, If ye have faith as a grain of mustard seed, ye shall say unto this mountain, Remove hence to yonder place; and it shall remove; and nothing shall be impossible unto you.

Here, Jesus teaches that if one has faith as small as a grain of mustard seed, then one can speak to a mountain and have it move to a different place.

Now think about it. God has stored enough power in a measure of faith as small as a mustard seed to move something as big as a mountain to a yonder place. Likewise, God has stored enough energy in a small amount of matter, such as a packet of sugar, to move something as big as the Washington Monument a fairly long distance.

Do you see the correlation? In both examples, a small quantity of faith (or a small quantity of matter) possesses enough energy to move a massive object a very long distance. In effect, Jesus was teaching that faith can have as much of an impact upon nature as would a nuclear explosion.

In light of the foregoing, consider the following: Having created all things (*see* John 1), Jesus must have understood the laws of physics when He made such statements. After all, He created them. Furthermore, since His statements about faith closely parallel Einstein's theory that small amounts of matter have enough atomic energy to move large objects long distances, I believe that Jesus was speaking quite literally when He said that a small amount of faith could move a mountain to a yonder place.

If Jesus had put enough atomic power in a literal grain of mustard seed to knock the Mount of Olives—or if not the whole thing, certainly a big chunk of it—into the nearby Sea of Galilee, then why wouldn't He store the same power in an equivalent measure of faith? After all, it was He, and not some modern theologian, who broached the subject of faith moving mountains.

While we can certainly expect that faith can move the spiritual obstacles in our lives, we must never forget that faith can (and will) also affect the world around us in quite a literal sense.

So why have we failed to see such prodigious displays of God's Power upon the topography of our planet? I hate to be a spoil-sport, but if no literal mountains have been moved in nearly 2,000 years, when it is now patently obvious that Jesus was speaking literally, then who is to say that faith, as Jesus describes, even exists?

The answer can be explained in Mark 11:22. There, Jesus instructs the disciples to "Have faith in God," or at least this is what the King James Version reads. A transliteration of this verse, as described in *Young's Literal Translation*, reads, "Have faith of God."³²

Now, there is a world of difference between *in* and *of*. The most important difference, at least from our perspective, is that when a person has faith *in* God, such faith is leaving the person and is being directed toward God. Conversely, when one has faith *of* God, the person is not the originator of said faith; the faith is coming from God and is directed toward man.

So what we have in a literal translation of this verse is the concept that faith comes from God and not from man. It is God who gives people faith. We cannot create faith; we cannot make faith out of thin air. Faith must come from God or it is not true faith.

On occasions too numerous to count or to document, I have heard Oral Roberts, Kenneth Copeland, and other Word of Faith preachers refer to this as being "the God-kind of faith." They teach that (1) God used faith to create the universe (Hebrews 11:3); (2) Christ commanded us to have the faith of God (*i.e.*, the "God-kind of faith"); (3) therefore, we have the right to utilize God's faith when we pray.

As one might suspect, this interpretation is highly controversial, especially with non-charismatics. For example, the Christian Research Institute ("CRI") has stated, "The whole idea that God has faith is completely foreign to the Bible.... God doesn't need to have faith.... The idea that we have to

imitate God's 'faith' is clearly unbiblical.... Faith is always object oriented: Faith in God not faith of God."³³

While I certainly do not wish to involve myself in any unnecessary theological controversy, especially since I have to deal with enough controversy in my day job as an attorney, I do think that both sides have valid points. However, at the same time, I believe that both sides are looking at this passage all wrong.

Let's step out of the spiritual mindset here for a moment. Just take off your Sunday-go-to-meeting clothes and pretend that we are talking about faith simply from the perspective of interpersonal human relationships. In such a context, answer this question: What is another word for *faith*?

How about *trust*?

Is it possible that Jesus was telling us to have the "faith of God," not so much from the "God-kind of faith" standpoint, but merely from a perspective of trust? If *faith* and *trust* are synonymous, then wouldn't the "faith of God" be equivalent to the "trust of God"?

Look at John 2:23-25. I have emphasized the relevant portions of the text:

Now when he was in Jerusalem at the passover, in the feast day, many believed in his name, when they saw the miracles which he did. (v. 23)

But Jesus did not commit himself unto them, because he knew all men, (v. 24)

And needed not that any should testify of man: for he knew what was in man. (v. 25)

Here we have people who believed in the Name of Jesus. If these people had been living today, we would have invited them—with no questions asked—into the fellowship of

believers. Nevertheless, even though they believed in Jesus, Jesus did not believe in them.

You see, while some Word of Faith teachers may be incorrect in describing the “faith of God” and how it works, their critics are just as wrong to say that God doesn’t have faith.

Certainly, God did not need to exercise faith when He created the universe. There is no indication in Hebrews 11:3 that God did anything by faith during the week of Creation. On the contrary, the passage teaches that through faith we (and not God, but we) understand that the universe was framed by God’s Word. To this extent, I believe that Word of Faith ministers are incorrect in their approach to this passage.

Nevertheless, God does need to exercise faith. If God intends for people to exercise power in accordance with His Will, He must find persons who can be trusted with His Power. Otherwise, God will have to exercise His Power unilaterally. Since repeated, unilateral uses of His Power would run counter to His desire to involve Christians in the work of His Kingdom, we must conclude that faith is not always object oriented as CRI contends.

My philosophy is simple. Faith is a two-way street. As we put more of our faith in God, by obeying His Word and the voice of His Spirit, even when such obedience would be to our own hurt, God will put more faith in us. As our faith in God grows, so will God’s faith in us grow. As God’s faith in us increases, God will entrust us with more of His Power.

Let’s go back to my observations concerning nuclear physics for just a moment. Given the present threat of terrorism, do you think that the United States government would entrust just anyone with weapons-grade plutonium or highly-enriched uranium? Of course not! If the Department of Energy were to give the average Joe access to nuclear

materiel, terrorists would have everything necessary to wreck havoc on the world.

I believe it's the same with God. Pay close attention to Luke 5:37-38:

And no man putteth new wine into old bottles; else the new wine will burst the bottles, and be spilled, and the bottles shall perish. (v. 37)

But new wine must be put into new bottles; and both are preserved. (v. 38)

If God were to entrust His Power with a person having a bad or otherwise immature character, the person would be unable to handle the power; he would be destroyed, and the power would be wasted. God knows that more harm than good will result if a selfish person gets hold of His Power. For this reason, God is not going to “cast His pearls to swine” (Matthew 7:6)

This point is further illustrated by what Jesus said at the conclusion of His discourse on faith in Mark 11:

And when ye stand praying, forgive, if ye have aught against any: that your Father also which is in heaven may forgive you your trespasses. (v. 25)

At first glance, this verse seems out of place, does it not? He is talking about faith moving mountains one minute, but the very next minute, He speaks of our duty to forgive. (We know that this verse relates to the preceding verses because it begins with the word *and*.) What is the nexus between faith and forgiveness?

If an unforgiving person were given the power to relocate a mountain simply by speaking to it, such a one might very well use that rock to crush his foe. Likewise, a bitter

person might use this supernatural power to exact revenge upon a hated enemy.

This fleshly anger is not how God operates. Indeed, as James puts it, “the wrath of man worketh not the righteousness of God.” (James 1:20). Instead, fleshly anger is an expression of man’s inability to maintain control of his own environment.

People get angry for one reason (and one reason only): They get angry when they lose the ability to exert control over their respective situations.

For example, when a person is offended, such an offense is usually the result of certain remarks or actions. With all things being equal, such a one would likely have avoided the offensive remarks or actions altogether if he had been given the opportunity. Alternatively, if such a one could have prevented the person who delivered the offensive remark or action from doing so, then he would have likely taken the necessary preventative measures. However, because the recipient of said remarks or actions could neither avoid them nor prevent them from being delivered, such a person became vulnerable to the aforementioned attacks. Being frustrated concerning this vulnerability—*i.e.*, this lack of control—the victim becomes angry.

The same could be said about persons who have been robbed or cheated. Under human law, the old adage concerning a man’s home being his castle pretty much holds true. In fact, several states have enacted the “Castle Doctrine,” which gives blanket criminal and civil immunity to homeowners who kill burglars. The reason for this doctrine is that a person should have exclusive dominion and control over what goes on inside his house, subject only to laws against felony acts (such as murder, rape, drug trafficking, and domestic abuse.)

Naturally, though, if someone else did assert unlawful control over your property, you would be angry, wouldn't you?

Pretty much, when one observes an angry person, one will notice that he is generally upset because he lacks control over a particular aspect of his life. When a person loses control over himself, someone else, or a piece of property, anger and frustration will usually follow.

Sometimes this anger is justifiable. For example, if someone were to burglarize one's house and then abscond with one's personal property, anger would be appropriate under the circumstances—provided that one does not let the sun go down on his wrath or otherwise sin in the process of being angry. (*See* Ephesians 4:26).

Then again, there are also times when people are angry for no valid reason. For example, when a child loses a board game, he may get mad. Likewise, if a wife were to claim that she “has a headache,” her husband might get angry over their lack of marital relations. In these situations, the person is angry simply because he was unable to exercise control over a particular matter. As such, the person's desire *to gain control* becomes superior to any desire the person might otherwise have *to yield control*.

A person who is not concerned about God's Plan for his life will likewise be unconcerned about working the Righteousness of God. Instead, such a person will rage anytime his plans are threatened or otherwise undermined. More times than not this rage will yield to unforgiveness, which, in turn, will transform into hatred.

When one prays, “Thy will be done,” such a person is praying for God's Righteousness to be fulfilled on this Earth. However, in order to pray for God's Righteousness to be fulfilled, one must demonstrate a measure of self-control. One must exercise control over his own temper. An angry person cannot work the Righteousness of God because an

angry person will never truly subordinate his own will to that of the Father. Instead, the angry person will likely use his God-given Anointing in a way that would bring disrespect to our Father.

Numbers 20 illustrates the dangers of mixing fleshly anger with God's Anointing:

And the LORD spake unto Moses, saying, (v. 7)

Take the rod, and gather thou the assembly together, thou, and Aaron thy brother, and speak ye unto the rock before their eyes; and it shall give forth his water, and thou shalt bring forth to them water out of the rock: so thou shalt give the congregation and their beasts drink. (v. 8)

And Moses took the rod from before the LORD, as he commanded him. (v. 9)

And Moses and Aaron gathered the congregation together before the rock, and he said unto them, Hear now, ye rebels; must we fetch you water out of this rock? (v. 10)

And Moses lifted up his hand, and with his rod he smote the rock twice: and the water came out abundantly, and the congregation drank, and their beasts also. (v. 11)

And the LORD spake unto Moses and Aaron, Because ye believed me not, to sanctify me in the eyes of the children of Israel, therefore ye shall not bring this congregation into the land which I have given them. (v. 12)

Here, the Lord states that Moses—the guy who wrote the first five books of the Bible, the man who communed with God for forty days and nights on Mount Sinai—did not believe God.

Now, correct me if I am wrong, but isn't believing God and having faith pretty much the same thing? Of course! They are synonymous.

Well then, what caused Moses to lose faith?

His anger did.

When Moses lost control of his temper, he made the wrong decisions during a national crisis. He exercised control over a situation in a way that was not pleasing to God. He tried to exercise God's Power in way that ran contrary to God's Plan. By doing so, Moses demonstrated that he now had more faith in his ability to "fetch water" for the masses than in God's ability to provide for His people. Moses showed that he believed that he should be in control, not God. As such, he suffered the consequences.

Just as President Harry Truman felt compelled to dismiss General Douglas MacArthur when the latter refused to obey a direct order, God knew that He had to fire Moses for his unwillingness to submit to His agenda. The Lord could no longer trust Moses to obey His directives.

If we desire God's Power, God must be able to trust us with it. We must have the "faith of God." We must value God's reputation more than our own. We must desire to build His kingdom and not our own. We must desire to use God's Power for God's purposes.

To the extent that we possess these character traits, we will be entrusted with God's Power, and we will be led down the Godly Path of Least Resistance.

Chapter
FIFTH SEMESTER:
“GIVE US THIS DAY OUR DAILY BREAD.”



The focus of the Lord's Prayer to this point has been placed upon God's character, reputation, kingdom and control.

We have learned that God's ability to take charge of the affairs of men is a direct function of the influence of His Kingdom. We have learned that God's Power will not flow into a person's life unless and until he submits to God's Plan and Purpose.

We have learned that God's Kingdom will expand only when His reputation is exalted. For when people begin to comprehend His immeasurable power, His boundless love, and His infinite wisdom, they will pledge their allegiance to our Lord, offering their bodies, souls and spirits to Him in a loving act of worship.

We have learned that the exaltation of His reputation is concomitant with the strength of His character. God is an exalted Father who loves His children deeply; He would pay any price, make any sacrifice, to better the lives of His children. Nevertheless, God is also the ultimate standard for objective truth. He will not jeopardize His ultimate plan for humanity in order to accommodate the whims of mere

mortals. It is this proper balance between love and purpose from which God garners such respect and adoration.

Now that we have put God first—now that we have sought the Kingdom of God and His Righteousness (*see* Matthew 6:33)—we now petition our Lord for our needs.

Naturally, the first order of business is survival. In order to be of service to God on this Earth, we must function biologically. One can only go so long without having his physical needs met. Although the Bible says that he who does not work does not eat (*see* II Thessalonians 3:10), I suppose that if one cannot eat, he will not have the energy to work. As such, food for our bellies is nearly as essential as is faith in our hearts.

In American society we take food for granted. With grocery stores on every block and restaurants on every corner, very few of us have experienced true hunger. Certainly there are exceptions to this statement. Indeed, one only has to recall the images of decent, upstanding people looting supermarkets in the wake of Hurricane Katrina to understand just how precious food is during a time of famine. Notwithstanding such calamities, which, thankfully, are few and far between, most Americans nevertheless have ready access to food—which, of course, may explain our nation's growing obesity problem.

You might not realize this, but food is so plentiful in the United States that our government will actually pay land owners not to grow crops on their land. That's right! Because wholesale food prices have dropped so low in recent decades, the United States Department of Agriculture has implemented a direct payment program where property owners are paid hundreds of millions of dollars each year to use farmland for other purposes. By encouraging farmers to reduce production, the government has caused food prices to increase. According to the *Washington Post*, the government

has disbursed more than \$1.3 billion for this program since the year 2000.³⁴

By using sophisticated agricultural tools—such as tractors and combines, fertilizers and pesticides—modern farmers enjoy substantially higher yields than did their counterparts in ancient Israel. It also doesn't hurt that American farms enjoy much more rainfall than do the farms of Jesus' day. The desert climate of Palestine is a far cry from the more temperate atmosphere of farm states like Iowa or Nebraska. Beyond this, the growers of ancient Israel were also being oppressed by Roman soldiers who, themselves, needed to be fed. For these reasons, an American who rests secure in the comfort of a fully-stocked pantry must consider just how scarce bread was when Jesus spoke these immortal words.

To illustrate this scarcity, take a closer look at the story of Jesus feeding the 5,000 in John 6. Let's begin our examination with verses 1-15:

After these things Jesus went over the sea of Galilee, which is the sea of Tiberias. (v. 1)

And a great multitude followed him, because they saw his miracles which he did on them that were diseased. (v. 2)

And Jesus went up into a mountain, and there he sat with his disciples. (v. 3)

And the passover, a feast of the Jews, was nigh. (v. 4)

When Jesus then lifted up his eyes, and saw a great company come unto him, he saith unto Philip, Whence shall we buy bread, that these may eat? (v. 5)

And this he said to prove him: for he himself knew what he would do. (v. 6)

Philip answered him, Two hundred pennyworth of bread is not sufficient for them, that every one of them may take a little. (v. 7)

One of his disciples, Andrew, Simon Peter's brother, saith unto him, (v. 8)

There is a lad here, which hath five barley loaves, and two small fishes: but what are they among so many? (v. 9)

And Jesus said, Make the men sit down. Now there was much grass in the place. So the men sat down, in number about five thousand. (v. 10)

And Jesus took the loaves; and when he had given thanks, he distributed to the disciples, and the disciples to them that were set down; and likewise of the fishes as much as they would. (v. 11)

When they were filled, he said unto his disciples, Gather up the fragments that remain, that nothing be lost. (v. 12)

Therefore they gathered them together, and filled twelve baskets with the fragments of the five barley loaves, which remained over and above unto them that had eaten. (v. 13)

Then those men, when they had seen the miracle that Jesus did, said, This is of a truth that prophet that should come into the world. (v. 14)

When Jesus therefore perceived that they would come and take him by force, to make him a king, he departed again into a mountain himself alone. (v. 15)

Here we see 5,000 men (and presumably that many women and children, if not more) following Christ to a mountain. Our Lord, being concerned for the wellbeing of this multitude, suggested to His disciples the idea of feeding the prodigious crowd. Phillip, being quite the economist, observed the scarcity of bread, noting that such a task would be insurmountable. Andrew reported that one boy was willing to part with a few loaves and fishes, but even he expressed doubt as to the sufficiency of such a donation.

Notwithstanding the skepticism of His own organization, Jesus commanded the disciples to distribute the food to the crowd. The disciples obeyed, and as they did, they witnessed a miracle. The five loaves and two fishes multiplied before their very eyes, creating enough food to fill the crowd and to produce twelve baskets full of leftovers!

The passage ends with a peculiar statement. Jesus noted that the people were so thrilled with this miracle that they were about to take Him by force and crown Him their King. In response, Jesus departed alone from the mountain.

Skipping down a bit, let's read verses 22-27:

The day following, when the people which stood on the other side of the sea saw that there was none other boat there, save that one whereinto his disciples were entered, and that Jesus went not with his disciples into the boat, but that his disciples were gone away alone; (v. 22)

(Howbeit there came other boats from Tiberias nigh unto the place where they did eat bread, after that the Lord had given thanks: (v. 23)

When the people therefore saw that Jesus was not there, neither his disciples, they also took shipping, and came to Capernaum, seeking for Jesus. (v. 24)

And when they had found him on the other side of the sea, they said unto him, Rabbi, when camest thou hither? (v. 25)

Jesus answered them and said, Verily, verily, I say unto you, Ye seek me, not because ye saw the miracles, but because ye did eat of the loaves, and were filled. (v. 26)

Labour not for the meat which perisheth, but for that meat which endureth unto everlasting life, which the Son of man shall give unto you: for him hath God the Father sealed. (v. 27)

After Jesus had escaped, the crowd figured where He had gone and pursued after Him. (Now, the passage doesn't say exactly how many chased after Him, but since the whole crowd had clamored to anoint Jesus king just the night before, I'm sure that this posse comprised a sizeable portion of those who had just been fed.)

Observe Jesus' reaction. It was not the disingenuous "Aw shucks, I am so flattered!" response that modern politicians would employ. Rather, Jesus called them on the carpet, pointing out their insincerity.

Instead of seeking after Jesus because His recent miracle had demonstrated His true status as Messiah, the crowd sought after Jesus because they wanted more food. The

reality that a miracle had happened was ancillary to the fact that they had been fed. The supernatural display of God's Power meant little to this crowd; what mattered was the food in their bellies. *How* Jesus had fed them was not nearly as important as the fact *that* Jesus had fed them.

Before we delve further into the passage, it should be noted that many Christians, even to this day, fall into this similar mindset. We are less concerned with the process and are more concerned with the favorable result. Instead of appreciating the fact that we have just witnessed a display of God's Power, we are often more preoccupied about the benefits we have just received.

Of course, this relates back to what we learned in Chapter Three. When we pray, "Thy Kingdom come," we are more concerned about the movement of the Kingdom, and not the end result of such motion. As we pray, "Thy Kingdom come," we desire to see the Kingdom of God move simply for the sake of watching it move, and not so much to see any particular result. So while we may desire to be fed or clothed or healed or protected, our satisfaction is not in the end result; rather our satisfaction is derived from how God has performed the task.

Perhaps this could be put another way. Christians and non-Christians alike have the tendency to seek after wealth simply for the sake of having it. Just go to any business school and ask the students why they want to get rich. Chances are their answers will utilize some sort of circular reasoning. ("I want to get rich because I want to get rich.") Oh yes, there may be some who truly have noble visions of creating wealth in order to achieve some high-minded purpose, but these people are few and far between. Rarely will one find a student who will describe in vivid detail what he plans to do with wealth, other than, perhaps, to use the money for his own gratification.

Although we should never seek after money or wealth simply for the sake of having it (as we often do), in contrast, we should seek after the Kingdom of God simply because we desire to see it expand. Rather than focusing upon the end result of our prayers (*i.e.*, the provision, the healing, the protection, or the success that we so desire), we should be more concerned about the Presence of God in our situation.

Instead of seeking after the “gift” (*i.e.*, the noun), we should seek after the “give” (*i.e.*, the verb). What God gives us is not nearly as important as how He gives it. Although the multitude clearly appreciated the gift (indeed, they wanted to crown Jesus king), they apparently didn’t appreciate the manner by which the gift was given—at least not to Jesus’ satisfaction.

I surmise that the multitude’s focus upon the miraculous supply of food, as opposed to the miracle itself, is circumstantial evidence of their lack. If food had been abundant during Jesus’ day, why would the crowd have crossed the Sea of Galilee to find Him? Why go to such trouble to obtain something for which one has no need?

Naturally, Jesus was correct about their intentions. Let’s continue with the above passage, starting at verse 32:

Then Jesus said unto them, Verily, verily, I say unto you, Moses gave you not that bread from heaven; but my Father giveth you the true bread from heaven. (v. 32)

For the bread of God is he which cometh down from heaven, and giveth life unto the world. (v. 33)

Then said they unto him, Lord, evermore give us this bread. (v. 34)

And Jesus said unto them, I am the bread of life: he that cometh to me shall never hunger; and he that believeth on me shall never thirst. (v. 35)

I am that bread of life. (v. 48)

Your fathers did eat manna in the wilderness, and are dead. (v. 49)

This is the bread which cometh down from heaven, that a man may eat thereof, and not die. (v. 50)

I am the living bread which came down from heaven: if any man eat of this bread, he shall live for ever: and the bread that I will give is my flesh, which I will give for the life of the world. (v. 51)

The Jews therefore strove among themselves, saying, How can this man give us his flesh to eat? (v. 52)

Then Jesus said unto them, Verily, verily, I say unto you, Except ye eat the flesh of the Son of man, and drink his blood, ye have no life in you. (v. 53)

Whoso eateth my flesh, and drinketh my blood, hath eternal life; and I will raise him up at the last day. (v. 54)

For my flesh is meat indeed, and my blood is drink indeed. (v. 55)

He that eateth my flesh, and drinketh my blood, dwelleth in me, and I in him. (v. 56)

As the living Father hath sent me, and I live by the Father: so he that eateth me, even he shall live by me. (v. 57)

This is that bread which came down from heaven: not as your fathers did eat manna, and are dead: he that eateth of this bread shall live for ever. (v. 58)

These things said he in the synagogue, as he taught in Capernaum. (v. 59)

Many therefore of his disciples, when they had heard this, said, This is an hard saying; who can hear it? (v. 60)

When Jesus knew in himself that his disciples murmured at it, he said unto them, Doth this offend you? (v. 61)

What and if ye shall see the Son of man ascend up where he was before? (v. 62)

It is the spirit that quickeneth; the flesh profiteth nothing: the words that I speak unto you, they are spirit, and they are life. (v. 63)

But there are some of you that believe not. For Jesus knew from the beginning who they were that believed not, and who should betray him. (v. 64)

And he said, Therefore said I unto you, that no man can come unto me, except it were given unto him of my Father. (v. 65)

From that time many of his disciples went back, and walked no more with him. (v. 66)

From this we can see that the very crowd that had been searching for Jesus on this day—and that had wanted to crown Him King the day before—now wanted to have nothing to do with Him.

Although they wanted Jesus to feed them physically, they did not want to be fed spiritually. Although they wanted to enjoy the material benefits of His miraculous power, they did not fully appreciate the import of this power to their spiritual development. Thus they stepped over dollars while trying to pick up dimes. Shallow and self-serving, they failed to appreciate the grace that was being offered. Just as Esau had been too concerned about his stomach to preserve his birthright, so were they too shortsighted to perceive their spiritual lack. Unwilling to address the deficiencies in their souls, they chose to reject the *total* provision that God had ordained for them.

Compare their reaction to that of blind Bartimaeus in Mark 10:46-52. Bartimaeus was sitting at the gates of Jericho, begging for someone to give him money or food. Then he heard that Jesus was near. Immediately his demeanor changed. Instead of begging for food, he started to plead for a miraculous healing. Instead of wanting Jesus to give him a quick financial fix, he desperately cried for Jesus to give him sight. The Lord obliged his request, healing him right then and there.

Immediately following the miracle, Bartimaeus was still hungry and penniless. Nevertheless, he abandoned his begging to follow Jesus in the way. Now that he could see, he no longer had an excuse to beg. Now that he had perception, he could work for his own keep instead of asking others to show him mercy.

People who seek Jesus for a quick financial fix often do so to their own detriment. In His mercy and grace, our Lord may well oblige their request but do nothing more. However, if such persons were to seek Jesus for perception instead, they would be able to address the underlying reason for their poverty. Like Bartimaeus, they could stop begging and start working.

Perhaps this is why the Model Prayer addresses God's character, reputation, and kingdom before it mentions man's needs. If our prayers focus primarily upon achieving the ends that we so desperately desire, even if such ends are noble and just, we may lose sight of the big picture and forget to digest the food for our souls. Being so focused upon our own needs, we may lack the spiritual perception necessary to walk in the fullness of God's Plan.

Unlike Bartimaeus, the crowd of more than 5,000 lacked this spiritual perception. As a result, they missed the opportunity to eat the Bread of Life. (*See* John 6:54.)

In any event, the story of Jesus feeding the multitude demonstrates the scarcity of bread in His day. Of course, the mere fact that thousands of hungry people were sitting on a mountain miles from home is not necessarily proof of this general scarcity. Even today, if thousands of people were removed from any source of food for a significant length of time, hunger would eventually set in. However, if such modern persons were to return to a typical city, where restaurants, convenience stores and supermarkets line every block, they probably would not seek after another free lunch from the same person—unless, of course, their poverty was so deep that they could not afford even the most inexpensive foodstuff.

In like fashion, I surmise that if the 5,000 men who had just been fed by Christ had possessed enough money to purchase bread, they would not have solicited Jesus for another fix—unless, of course, the supply of bread on the

open market was meager. Either way, their reaction to Christ underscores just how scarce bread was for these 5,000+ individuals. When juxtaposed against the inefficient agricultural methods, the lack of welfare services, and the presence of an oppressive foreign regime, the shortsighted response of this rather prodigious crowd supports the notion that life was unbearable for the poor in Jesus' day.

A person who has been "flat-broke" will probably understand why the crowd reacted as they did. I certainly do. Although by God's grace and mercy I have never had to file for bankruptcy, for a few years there I very well could have.

At the turn of the twenty-first century, my wife and I were so strapped for cash that we literally lived off our overdraft protection. On one occasion, when we had absolutely no money in our bank account, my wife and I needed gas for our two cars. We drove both cars to the gas station where I proceeded to fill my car first. I inserted my debit card into the pay-at-the-pump computer. With plenty of overdraft protection, I knew that the bank would cover the debit. However, I also knew that the bank would charge me an overdraft fee of about seventeen dollars per transaction. Since I didn't want to get charged twice, after I finished fueling my car, but before I deactivated the pump, I handed the nozzle to my wife, who then filled her vehicle's tank.

You have probably heard the expression "silence is deafening." Well, if money were like sound, the silence of poverty would be deafening. At virtually every waking moment, a poor person will think about the money he does not have. Knowing that one cannot afford even the simplest pleasure—such as a night at the movies or dinner at a fast-food restaurant—is downright depressing. One goes to work, gets paid, and then, even before he can deposit the money into the bank, his paycheck is already gone.

Every now and then, my wife and I would get a surprise check in the mail from a beloved relative. Whenever that

would happen, there would be a sense of euphoria. For just a little while, the pressure of poverty would ease, and we would feel like we were on top of the world. Naturally, we would call to thank our benefactor and voice our praises to God in the process. After a while, though, this happiness would recede as soon as the money was spent.

It eventually got to a point where I began to think that all of my problems would wash away—once and for all—as soon as I struck it rich (or at least got out of debt). Because my most pressing concerns were financial, I assumed that money would solve all of my problems. So, I began to look for ways to facilitate a quick fix. I paid \$100 to join a network marketing operation—one which turned out to be a pyramid scheme. (I never got my money back.) For several months, I made numerous attempts to become a contestant on the game show *Who Wants to Be a Millionaire?* (In fact, I came mighty close to becoming one. Really! I had five auditions.) Nevertheless, no matter what I did, I still could not break out of my poverty.

I learned an important lesson during this difficult time. Riches can place so much weight on a person that his movement can be restricted thereby. If I had become successful selling life insurance in Arkansas, I would have never moved to Oklahoma. Likewise, if I had become rich in Oklahoma, I would have never gone to law school in Virginia. Back then, to one degree or another, my poverty motivated me. As long as I lived in a dry and barren place, there was little need for me to set down permanent roots. Without roots to tie me down, I became flexible; God could tell me where He wanted me to go, and I would obey quite willingly. Because I was willing and obedient, God could equip me to accomplish the tasks that He has ordained for me—empowering me to fulfill the dreams He has placed in my heart.

In retrospect, I know that the Bible is correct in teaching “they that will be rich fall into temptation and a snare, and

into many foolish and hurtful lusts, which drown men in destruction and perdition.” (I Timothy 6:9) In the Greek, the phrase “they that will” means “those that intend to.”³⁵ This passage clearly states that those who desire to be rich will fall into temptation.

In my particular situation, I wanted to get rich quickly and to make a name for myself in the process. My desire for wealth, however, caused me to make a grievous financial mistake. I foolishly left a stable government job in order to take a commission-only sales job...while my wife was pregnant, no less! (For any reader over the age of forty, now would be the appropriate time to hum the theme to *Dragnet*: “*Dum-de-dum-dum!*”)

I have since learned that if we desire to avoid unnecessary pitfalls in our lives, then we cannot be in love with money, because, as the next verse proves, the love of money, is the root of all evil. (v. 10) Indeed, a covetous person cannot walk the Godly Path of Least Resistance.

Although this particular time in my life was difficult, I wouldn’t trade my experiences for all the riches in the world. This is not to say that I want to relive these experiences. (No way!) However, as stressful as my life was at the time, the grace that I received—the love, the joy, the peace that God gave me—was precious.

Look closely at Mark 11:12-14, 20 (listed below with emphasis added):

And on the morrow, when they were come from Bethany, he was hungry: (v. 12)

And seeing a fig tree afar off having leaves, he came, if haply he might find any thing thereon: and when he came to it, he found nothing but leaves; for the time of figs was not yet. (v. 13)

And Jesus answered and said unto it, No man eat fruit of thee hereafter for ever. And his disciples heard it. (v. 14)

And in the morning, as they passed by, they saw the fig tree dried up from the roots. (v. 20)

At first glance, it is clear that Jesus cursed the fig tree because it didn't bear any fruit. By analogy, one might conclude that if we Christians do not bear fruit, we may also be cursed and therefore dry up from the roots. As good as this analysis may be, it misses a very important point: It was not the season for figs; accordingly, the tree was not expected to have any fruit. Nevertheless, Jesus cursed the tree and it died.

The point of this passage is that we must bear fruit out of season if we ever plan to bear fruit in season. If we want to enjoy life when times are good, then we must learn how to enjoy life when times are bad.

It's easy to demonstrate love in an atmosphere of complete acceptance. It's easy to be joyful when everything is turning up roses. It's easy to be at peace when one is relaxing on a beach. Love, joy and peace are expected during these times because these fruits are in season. When times are tough, however, no one is expected to be loving or joyful or at peace. No, in those circumstances, one is expected—at least by the world's standards—to be resentful or depressed or stressed. Thus, when times are difficult, the fruit of the Spirit is considered to be out of season.

Of course, as this passage demonstrates, Jesus looks for fruit when it is out of season. Moreover, if Jesus finds that one is unfruitful during a bad time, one may never have the chance to bear fruit during a good time.

One who is incapable of showing love to an enemy will never be able to appreciate love from a friend. One who is incapable of being optimistic during a time of defeat will certainly be pessimistic during a time of victory. One who is incapable of relaxing during a time of stress will remain anxious during a time of rest. One who rages when plans are thwarted will never be satisfied when goals are achieved.

Perhaps this is why God chooses not to burden us with too much of His blessings at any given time. We all want acceptance from our peers. We all want to be successful. We all want freedom from the stresses of life. However, too much of a good thing can become a curse. One who is accustomed to total acceptance may be incapable of adjusting to the most insignificant sleight. Likewise, one who is accustomed to total victory may be incapable of processing the most inconsequential defeat.

Even though bread is essential for survival, and although money is necessary to pay the bills, if one accumulates too much of either, more harm than help may result. As the economists will attest, there is a point of diminishing returns. Bread will spoil if it is not eaten in a timely manner; therefore, it does not benefit a person to hoard it. Likewise, if too much bread is consumed, then over time obesity will result. Since obesity causes diabetes, heart attacks, and other illnesses, it follows that the over-consumption of life-sustaining bread can, in fact, cause death.

Likewise, the over-accumulation of wealth can destroy a person. Just imagine what it would be like for the average person to win a \$200 million lottery. One minute, one is working for a living, having a normal life; but the next minute, one is a multi-millionaire, capable of purchasing anything he wants. Suddenly, friends and family want to hang out at his place, eat his food, drink his wine, and swim in his pools. Soon, these friends start begging the winner for money to pay their bills or to finance their businesses. Of

course, the winner has a calculator; the winner knows that if he gives money to everyone who asks for help, before long, the money will disappear. So the winner draws a line and says “no” to their supplications. Of course, the “friends” get mad and storm off. Before long, the winner starts putting up walls—both literally and figuratively—to separate him from the average Joes that were once his buddies.

The wealthy tend to isolate themselves from the poor. Sometimes this isolation is necessary to protect the rich from those who would steal from them—or even kill them. Often, though, this isolation serves only to elevate the rich from the commoners who live below. “Because I have money,” a rich man may think, “I deserve to be separated from the riff-raff.” Certainly, wealth, if placed in the hands of a selfish or unprepared person, can drive a wedge between that person and those who may be in financial need.

Perhaps this is why we are to pray for *our daily* bread.

In the first place, this section of the Model Prayer should be for the fulfillment of all of our collective needs. I do not believe that God would be honored if we were to pray exclusively for our needs without considering the similar needs of others. Likewise, I do not believe God wants for us to pray for blessings just so that we may hoard them all to ourselves.

In Exodus 16, God began to provide the Israelites with “manna.” Each day, a small, round piece of wafer would appear on the ground after the morning dew had left. Moses explained to the multitude, “This is the thing which the LORD hath commanded, Gather of it every man according to his eating, an omer for every man, according to the number of your persons; take ye every man for them which are in his tents.” (Exodus 16:16). Since some families had more persons than others, it followed that some Israelites would gather more, while others gathered less. (v. 17) Despite the fact that some families had more food than others, “he that

gathered much had nothing over, and he that gathered little had no lack.” (v. 18)

Moses commanded the Israelites not to leave any of the manna until morning. (v. 19) Of course, some people disobeyed this command, and when they did, the manna bred worms and began to stink. (v. 20) However, there was one exception to this command. On the morning before the Sabbath, the Israelites were instructed to take two days worth of food. Then, when they held food over from the Sabbath evening to the Sabbath morning, the manna would not spoil. (vv. 22-25).

In this passage, we observe how God provided for the Israelites. The children of Israel were instructed to take a certain amount of manna per person each morning. Given that food was being rationed, one might assume that God had provided a meager supply of manna—just enough for everyone to “barely get by.” However, this assumption would be incorrect.

The Bible explains that the manna would melt when “the sun waxed hot.” (v. 21). Since we know that some people kept manna overnight in disobedience to Moses’ command, it follows then that these Israelites possessed certain amounts of manna inside their tents, long after the sun had set. Since the fields would have been the only places where manna would have been exposed to sunlight, we may safely conclude that God rained more than enough manna each morning to fill the stomachs of His chosen people.

God covered the ground with an over-abundant supply of manna each morning, knowing full well that most of it would be wasted—that most of it would be melted by the heat of the desert sun. Nevertheless, God commanded the Israelites to gather only what they needed, only when they needed it.

This passage clearly demonstrates that the Lord is the “God of more than enough” (as my former employers, Oral

and Richard Roberts would teach). However, it also proves that He is a God of discipline. Simply because a person has access to certain resources does not necessarily mean that he should use them.

In one respect, by illustrating God's abundant supply, this passage tends to support the prosperity message (which teaches that God wants to bless Christians with material blessings). In another respect, it tends to contradict the prosperity message by demonstrating how the Israelites were restricted from accessing this surplus food.

Jesus had the power to put gold coins into the mouths of fishes. (*See* Matthew 17:27.) On at least two occasions, He directed certain commercial fishermen to increase their harvest by way of supernatural means. (*See* Luke 5, John 21.) With the power to create both the instruments of demand (*i.e.*, gold coins) and the commodities of supply (*i.e.*, fishes), Jesus could have become the wealthiest man in Judea, if not the whole world. Yet, He once said that He did not have a place to lay His head. (*See* Matthew 8:20.)

Even though Jesus had the power to become wealthy, He possessed an even greater power—the power of self-control.

It would be a stunning display of God's Power if one could order money to jump into his bank account. Even so, it would be a greater miracle if such a one were to live on a budget and spend his money wisely even though he could access all the money in the world.

As we will soon discover in a later chapter, self-control is essential for a person who endeavors to travel down the Godly Path of Least Resistance. This is especially true with regard to money.

When one has a pressing need of which he wishes to bring to God's attention, it takes discipline to begin one's prayer by focusing upon God's character. (I know that when I have a need, my first inclination is to jump right in and start

praying for it.) Likewise, it takes self-discipline to humble oneself before the Lord, to pray, in effect, for God's reputation to be advanced, even at the expense of one's own esteem in the community.

Naturally, self-discipline is paramount when one works to advance the agenda of someone else. As just about any hourly employee will attest, the temptation to goof off when the boss isn't looking can be irresistible, especially if internet access is at one's fingertips. Likewise, it can be just as difficult to pray for God's Kingdom to advance when, deep down, one really wants to exercise as much control as possible.

By the time one gets to the sections of the Model Prayer where he can pray for his own needs to be met, he must demonstrate a considerable amount of self-control. Otherwise, one might gather too much manna and, as a result, the Heavenly blessing may become a magnet for worms and decay. Besides, as we have learned in the previous chapter, God is not going to give a person the ability to move a mountain unless He is certain that such a one can handle the responsibility that comes with His Anointing.

Just about every miracle of Christ happened instantaneously. Even when Jesus cursed the fig tree in Mark 11, the tree withered within the space of a day. When Jesus wanted a miracle, it happened that day. It didn't happen a week later or a month later. It happened that day!

Now what are the first four words of this section of the Lord's Prayer?

"Give us *this day*..."

Our "daily bread" is of little use tomorrow or the day after. Rather, our "daily bread" must come "this day" for it to be of any use. If, in fact, today were God's appointed time to meet a particular need in one's life, then having this need met tomorrow would be too late. Therefore, we must demonstrate enough faith to do as Jesus did, *i.e.*, to see God's hand move immediately. When we pray, we must believe—not

in our heads, but in our hearts—that we have received our answer (Mark 11:24). Our faith must grow to a level where we can truly expect for God to “give us *this day* our daily bread.” If we can get to that point in our faith, then fear of scarcity will have no place in our hearts and minds.

As long as we are truly cognizant of what our precise needs are for a given period of time, we will not attempt to obtain that which will invariably spoil and produce a foul stench. Instead, as we seek after those blessings that God has intended for us to have on “this day,” we can pray with full assurance that God will supply those needs instantaneously. Indeed, if we seek to accumulate tomorrow’s provision now, we will overlook today’s blessings.

Some time ago, I was struggling with worry. I went to my friend, Johnny Buckner, who is a local pastor. As we were praying, he reminded me that God’s grace and His timing go hand in hand. If God has not given me grace, he said, it is because I don’t need it. If I feel worry, if I lack peace about a situation, it is because God is not giving me grace to handle that problem right then.

From this message, I reasoned that if God wasn’t going to help me *right now*, it is probably because I didn’t need help *right now*. I concluded that if God didn’t think that I needed help *right now*, then I probably didn’t have a problem worth being concerned about *right now*. So when thoughts of worry came to mind, I would not let my mind go down that path. I instead chose to let God provide for tomorrow’s needs tomorrow.

If we become contented with God’s daily (or periodic) provision, then we will not worry about tomorrow’s (or the next period’s) lack. We will neither attempt to hoard resources that we presently do not need, nor will we embrace problems that we currently do not have. Instead, we will be at peace as we ride down the Godly Path of Least Resistance.

Chapter
SIXTH SEMESTER:
“AND FORGIVE US OUR DEBTS, AS WE
FORGIVE OUR DEBTORS.”



There are two basic types of people who retain the services of a plaintiff's attorney: (1) those who seek to be restored to their previous situation; and (2) those who seek to exact revenge upon their enemies. Since becoming a paralegal, and later an attorney, I have witnessed both types of people. From these encounters, I have learned that one who is seeking only to be restored will be content with just about any resolution; conversely, a person seeking revenge will hardly be satisfied with any result.

Perhaps this is why this section of the Model Prayer is placed after the section concerning “our daily bread.” One who understands the contentment that comes from God's daily (or periodic) provision will have little difficulty embracing forgiveness. One who understands that God is the source for every good and perfect gift (*see* James 1:17) will also understand that His grace will cover every shortfall in our lives—even those deficiencies that are created by our fellow human beings.

As we have already learned, we cannot truly be contented unless we understand that God is in control. Furthermore, we cannot comprehend God's control over a situation unless

we perceive that His kingdom has invaded that situation. To the extent that we must pray for God's Kingdom to invade a situation, we must first embrace humility and choose to exalt God's reputation over our own statures. This desire for humility is derived from a revelation of the Heavenly Father's character.

All of these lessons are reminders of our own inadequacies. Our character will never be equal to the character of God, except to the extent that we are allowed to exchange ours for His via the sacrifice of Christ. Likewise, our reputation will never be as exalted as His; no matter how well-liked and respected we may become, we will never earn the respect of angels (at least not by our own rights). To the extent that we may be given dominion or control over this world, that control will always be subordinate to God's; even if one were to become a benevolent world dictator, one could never control the sun, the moon and the stars. Simply put, none of us can measure to God in our own strength, nor can we ever relate to Him as an equal.

Given our natural inability to relate to God on His level, we must depend upon His grace and mercy if we expect to enjoy any semblance of a relationship with Him. Our ability to access God's grace and mercy, however, is directly proportionate to our willingness to extend grace and mercy to others. As an epilogue to the Model Prayer, Jesus said in Matthew 6:14-15:

For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you: (v. 14)

But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses. (v. 15)

To illustrate this principle, Jesus told a parable concerning an unforgiving servant in Matthew 18:

Therefore is the kingdom of heaven likened unto a certain king, which would take account of his servants. (v. 23)

And when he had begun to reckon, one was brought unto him, which owed him ten thousand talents. (v. 24)

But forasmuch as he had not to pay, his lord commanded him to be sold, and his wife, and children, and all that he had, and payment to be made. (v. 25)

The servant therefore fell down, and worshipped him, saying, Lord, have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. (v. 26)

Then the lord of that servant was moved with compassion, and loosed him, and forgave him the debt. (v. 27)

But the same servant went out, and found one of his fellow-servants, which owed him an hundred pence: and he laid hands on him, and took him by the throat, saying, Pay me that thou owest. (v. 28)

And his fellow-servant fell down at his feet, and besought him, saying, Have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. (v. 29)

And he would not: but went and cast him into prison, till he should pay the debt. (v. 30)

So when his fellow-servants saw what was done, they were very sorry, and came and told unto their lord all that was done. (v. 31)

Then his lord, after that he had called him, said unto him, O thou wicked servant, I forgave thee all that debt, because thou desiredst me: (v. 32)

Shouldest not thou also have had compassion on thy fellow-servant, even as I had pity on thee? (v. 33)

And his lord was wroth, and delivered him to the tormentors, till he should pay all that was due unto him. (v. 34)

So likewise shall my heavenly Father do also unto you, if ye from your hearts forgive not every one his brother their trespasses. (v. 35)

In this story, a king decides to take account of his servants. One servant owed him 10,000 talents. According to the *Jewish Encyclopedia*, there were four types of talents in ancient Israel: (1) the heavy gold talent, weighing 103 pounds avoirdupois, (2) the light gold talent, weighing a little over 54 pounds avoirdupois, (3) the heavy silver talent, weighing 96 pounds avoirdupois, (4) and the light silver talent, weighing about 48 pounds avoirdupois.³⁶ So depending upon whether the 10,000 talents were heavy or light and whether the specie in use was gold or silver, the servant's debt could have varied greatly. Still, it is undeniable that the servant owed more money than he could have ever repaid.

From a practical standpoint, there exists no problem in having debt—until, that is, the loan is called. Here, the servant faced that situation. Making matters worse was the

fact that the creditor was the king himself. Had the creditor been a fellow servant, at least the debtor could have argued his case before an impartial monarch. Unfortunately for this debtor, the king was the victim, the only witness, and the sole source for the law (*i.e.*, *Rex lex*). Pretty much, the debtor was toast.

Facing the insurmountable odds of winning his case, the debtor did what any lawyer would have advised. He copped a plea. He fell on his face and begged the king for mercy.

Now before we go any further, can we glean anything about the king, at least from this stage of the story?

First, it is apparent that the king had accounts with his servants. Since he was the creditor, and since his servants were the debtors, we may surmise that this monarch had surplus income (or as the stockbrokers would say, risk capital) to invest. Like all investors, this king wanted a positive return on his investments. Like all kings, he had plenty of assets to invest. Although he controlled a lot of stuff, he still desired more than what he already possessed.

Second, we may surmise that this king was fair and just. Having absolute control over his kingdom, the king could have expanded his portfolio by way of police power or military force. If the king had coveted the assets of one of his subjects, his majesty could have simply ordered his guards to commandeer the property for the use and enjoyment of the crown. Likewise, if the king had coveted the assets from a neighboring kingdom, he could have used military force to expand the boundaries of his dominion (assuming, of course, that his was the stronger army). Instead, the king chose to use the free market to advance his agenda: He loaned money to his servants, knowing full well that he might lose his investment.

Third, we may also surmise that the king was concerned about the wellbeing of his servants. Neglecting for now the selfless act of mercy and kindness that is presented later in

the passage, the king must have understood that by loaning money to his servants he enabled them to live better, more rewarding lives. Certainly, we may presume that the king was the wealthiest person in his dominion. As we have established, the king had more wealth than he could have possibly enjoyed. Like a bank, the king loaned this excess capital to his servants; by doing so, the king afforded his servants with the opportunity to start their own businesses and to create wealth of their own.

The servant referenced in this passage had been loaned a large sum of money. For perspective, consider that in Matthew 25:14-30 Jesus tells of a king who had entrusted three of his servants with ten talents, five talents, and one talent, respectively. Here, in the parable of the unforgiving servant, the king is said to have given the servant 10,000 talents. By juxtaposing the two parables, we can see that Jesus is emphasizing that the king had placed an unusual amount of trust in this servant. Still, despite the servant's creditworthiness, the servant nevertheless wasted the king's resources because, when the loan came due, he had nothing to show for this investment.

When the king realized that the servant was broke, his majesty decided to cut his losses. The king decided to sell the man, his wife, and his children into slavery. At least then, the king reasoned, he would get back some of his money.

Of course, the servant couldn't handle the idea of losing his family or becoming a slave. So he begged for the king to give him just a little more time to come up with the cash.

Surprisingly, the king answered his prayer—and then some. Instead of giving the servant more time to pay the debt, the king altogether released him. The king could have given him a few more months, or maybe even a few more years, to come up with the money. If that had happened, it would have been a slam dunk for the servant. The king also could have placed the servant on a flexible payment plan.

That, too, would have been a win. Instead, the king simply told him to forget about it. The servant didn't have to pay any of it; he was in the clear.

Now think of the times when you have been blessed beyond your wildest expectation. Think of a time when you entered into a terrible situation, only to watch it transform into something that surpassed your wildest dreams. If you have ever experienced any situation like this, how did you react? Were you humbled by the blessing you had received, or did you smugly think that you had deserved it all along?

Of course, if you had been living by the Lord's Prayer—if you had been traversing down the Godly Path of Least Resistance—you would have been an expert on humility. Your prayers for God's Name to be hallowed, for example, would have demonstrated your desire for His reputation to be exalted, even to the detriment of your own stature. Your prayers for God's Kingdom to come and for His Will to be done would have confirmed your submission to the Lord's authoritative purpose for your life. Your prayers for God to supply your daily bread on an as needed basis would have established your complete dependence upon God for the essentials of life itself. Therefore by insulating your heart from the very ingredients of pride, *i.e.*, the desires for glory, power, and wealth, you would have foregone any significant inclination to become arrogant. Thus, you would have developed a greater appreciation for the gifts that your loving Father had so richly bestowed.

Apparently, the servant did not appreciate the rather prodigious gift of his king. After receiving an unexpected pardon from the monarch, he displayed his true colors to another servant. The original servant went out from the king's court and confronted a fellow servant about an overdue debt. As the text would indicate, this particular debt was considerably minute. Nevertheless, when the fellow servant presented the identical petition that the original servant had submitted to

the king just moments before, the latter refused to convey any grace or mercy to his debtor. Instead, he grabbed his fellow servant's throat and ordered that he be sent to prison.

Before we delve further into this passage, we must observe the following: The original servant had been given the break of a lifetime. He had owed the supreme ruler a debt that he could hardly dream of repaying. As a result, the monarch had decided to sell this man and his entire family into slavery to cover a fraction of these losses. However, after the original servant had begged and pleaded and cried like a baby, the king displayed mercy and completely forgave the debt! He and his family had been saved by the grace and mercy of this benevolent king. What a blessing!

Although the anecdote I am about to tell was the subject of the national media, this story is a bit more significant to me since it involves places where I lived as a child.

In 1971, Larry Stewart of Bruce, Mississippi was homeless, without work, and desperately hungry. One morning, he was in the town of Houston, Mississippi, which is about twenty-five miles from Bruce. He walked into the "Dixie Diner," a small cafe on the corner of Mississippi Highways 8 and 15, just a few yards from the Chickasaw County Courthouse. He ordered some food, knowing full well that he didn't have the funds to pay for the bill. After he had finished eating, he patted his pockets, pretending to have lost his wallet. Then he took his act to a new level, stepping outside to look for a wallet that did not exist.

The owner of the Diner, Ted Horn, was a slightly older gentleman who saw right through this young man's facade. But instead of calling him a liar or otherwise making a scene, he pulled \$20 out of his wallet and said, "Son, I think you dropped this." Then Mr. Horn proceeded to ring up the meal, giving young Larry the change.

The act of kindness changed Larry's life. As he left the Dixie Diner, he made a vow to himself that he would one

day become wealthy just so that he could help others in their times of need.

After getting his life back together, Larry moved to Kansas City, Missouri, and started working for a cable television company. After “Ma Bell” broke up, he formed his own long-distance telephone company. By the mid-1990’s, he had become a millionaire.

From the time he started working for the cable television company, to his death in 2007, Larry Stewart would dress up as Santa Claus and give \$100 bills to strangers on the street. Over the course of twenty-six years, he handed out \$1.3 million. In 1999, he located Ted Horn, and repaid him that original \$20, plus an extra \$10,000.³⁷

Larry Stewart, in one respect, was like the original servant in the above passage. He and the original servant each owed a debt that they couldn’t repay, and they both experienced unexpected grace and mercy from a person who could have used legal process against them. Unlike the unmerciful servant, Larry Stewart demonstrated his appreciation—not just when it happened, but also for the rest of his life. Instead of taking this merciful act for granted, as did the original servant, Larry Stewart became motivated to repeat this act of kindness thousands of times over.

How do you think the passage in Matthew would have ended had the original servant behaved like Larry Stewart? He probably would have looked for his fellow servant, but instead of wringing his neck, he would have hugged his neck; instead of demanding repayment, he would have forgiven his fellow servant. At the least, he would have given the guy a break, allowing him the opportunity to repay the debt over time.

Of course, the original servant didn’t do this. When the original servant stared into the eyes of his debtor while clutching the man’s throat, he failed to observe his own reflection. He was so detached, so absorbed with his own needs,

that he failed to recognize his own hypocrisy. By holding his fellow servant to a greater standard than he was willing to accept for himself, the original servant demonstrated his total incapacity for empathy. His narcissism approached the psychopathic.

The original servant was so focused in his pursuit of his fellow-servant that he confronted his debtor in public, showing no regard for civilized discourse. Instead of waiting until the fellow servant was away from the king's other servants, the original servant displayed the full measure of his wrath for the entire world to see. He had no discretion. He had no tact. He had only his thirst for retribution.

When the king learned of the original servant's behavior, his majesty became angry at the original servant's indifference. He became so angry that he revoked his pardon and ordered that the man be tormented.

This reaction is quite telling.

In the final analysis, a pardon, such as the one that was given to the original servant, is nothing more than a gift. By forgiving the servant's debt, the king gave his debtor something of great value.

Normally, the recipient of a gift is free to use the bequest any way he would like, irrespective of the gift's intrinsic value. For example, after one gives another person a car, the grantor cannot demand the vehicle's return; the recipient is now the owner. Now, if the benefactor had granted the vehicle to the recipient in exchange for certain promises, then perhaps the original owner could repossess the car if these promises were broken. However, without some form of contract, a benefactor loses all interest in an object when he gives it away.

Forgiving a debt is no different than giving the debtor the assets necessary to repay the loan. For all intents and purposes, the king in this parable had given the original servant 10,000 talents. Moreover, from the text of the story,

it may be surmised that the king had issued no strings to this pardon. The pardon was a full and unequivocal waiver of the king's right to be compensated for his loss. Therefore, one could have assumed that the king had no interest in how the servant would utilize his pardon. Surprisingly, though, the king reasserted his claim to the 10,000 talents once he learned of the original servant's callous, unforgiving demeanor.

Although modern jurisprudence would prevent a person from collecting a debt for which a valid release has been tendered, the king in this parable was an absolute monarch who could write (or if need be, re-write) the law to suit his ends. Thus, the king was under no obligation to forever discharge the original servant's debt. As the monarch, he had the prerogative to change his mind if the situation warranted such a variance.

When his majesty heard of the original servant's behavior, the monarch immediately recognized just how little the servant valued his pardon. The devaluation of such a priceless gift so enraged the king that he not only revoked the pardon, but he also ordered that the servant be tormented until he repaid the entire debt. This was a greater punishment than what the original servant had avoided with the pardon.

At the start of the parable, the original servant and his family were to be sold into slavery to cover the debt to the king. Had this occurred, the servant's new master might have purchased his entire family in one lot. Another possibility: The new master might have released him at some point in time. At least under the first scenario, the original servant would have enjoyed some measure of hope.

In sharp contrast, the original servant was now to be tormented until he repaid every last penny, something that would probably never happen. In addition, he would likely never see his family again, as their fate had not been addressed by the king's most recent edict. Only he would be subjected to tormenters; not his family. So while the servant

would feel the lashes from his royal tormenters, he would remain isolated from his family until this unredeemable debt had been paid in full.

Now let's focus upon this isolation for just a moment. Take a person who has been wronged: say, a victim of violent crime, or perhaps someone who has been wrongfully terminated from his job. Dreams are shattered, hopes are dashed, and pain is as real as the sun in the sky on a cloudless day. If the victim isn't careful, he may become bitter. The more he dwells upon the pain, the more that his life will become defined by this wrongful act. This change in identity will make it impossible for friends and family to relate to the victim anymore. Before long, siblings will act like distant cousins, and close friends will seem like mere acquaintances.

Unfortunately, bitterness is a repulsive character trait. As a person becomes more embittered, the person will become more isolated. A vicious cycle will invariably result. The initial rejection leads to bitterness; bitterness leads to more rejection; more rejection leads to more bitterness; and the cycle continues.

With no one willing to listen, the victim will do anything to be heard. In order to draw attention to their plight, some will inflict pain upon themselves by drinking excessively, taking illegal drugs, having illicit sex, or even by attempting suicide. Others will try to inflict pain on the wrongdoer by way of violence or vindictive litigation. Still others will lash out at innocent bystanders. The victim may abuse a spouse or a child, or as we have seen in recent years, the victim may take a gun and inflict mass murder upon rank strangers.

On the day he resigned from office in disgrace, President Richard Nixon addressed the White House staff, instructing them: "Never be petty. Always remember, others may hate you, but those that hate you don't win unless you hate them, and then you destroy yourself."³⁸

An embittered person will never enjoy life to its fullest because such a one will remain isolated from God. Our Lord is the fountainhead of life. He is the source of all good things. Therefore, if one is out of fellowship with God, one cannot enjoy the precious blessings of God. Hence the reason we must learn to forgive.

If we forgive, we shall enjoy the continued grace and mercy of our Lord. If we choose to hold grudges and harbor resentment, however, we shall forfeit access to this forgiveness and invite God's judgment into our lives. It cannot get any simpler than that.

Unfortunately, it is extremely difficult to forgive. We may know that we should be merciful. From a logical standpoint, we may even desire to be forgiving. However, pain and anguish are derived from our emotions. As we think more about our heartache, we are invariably reminded of the offense. Conversely, as we think more about the offense, the more angry and bitter we become. Alas, it is one vicious cycle!

To break free from the cycle of unforgiveness, one must first deal with the pain. In the same way that a person who has been stabbed must stop the bleeding, so too must a person who is struggling with unforgiveness put a stop to the offense. Keep in mind, however, that one who has a forgiving attitude will deal with an offense differently than one who is vindictive.

For most of my life, I believed that forgiveness equated to passivity and that, by definition, any form of confrontation—particularly litigation—was tantamount to unforgiveness. As a teenager, I reasoned that a forgiving person would not desire to be compensated or to otherwise be restored. Instead, I reasoned that a forgiving person would simply let it go and “take one for the team.”

Since then, I have experienced certain situations that have caused me to examine the Bible more closely. As a result of

this study, I have concluded that it is possible for a person to stand up for his rights without demonstrating unforgiveness. In fact, I have found that confrontation is essential for the type of forgiveness that we are required to manifest. As long as the confrontation intends to restore a relationship as opposed to destroying it, then it is not unforgiveness.

Look closely at Matthew 18:15-17:

Moreover if thy brother shall trespass against thee, go and tell him his fault between thee and him alone: if he shall hear thee, thou hast gained thy brother. (v. 15)

But if he will not hear thee, then take with thee one or two more, that in the mouth of two or three witnesses every word may be established. (v. 16)

And if he shall neglect to hear them, tell it unto the church: but if he neglect to hear the church, let him be unto thee as an heathen man and a publican. (v. 17)

First, this passage applies specifically to disputes between fellow Christians. This passage talks of “thy brother” in verse 15 and “the church” in verse 17. In context, both phrases would indicate the fellowship of Christian believers. So for now, we shall only discuss how we are to respond to other Christians when they commit wrong.

When a Christian fails another believer, the aggrieved person must first confront the wrongdoer in private (v. 15). The purpose of this confrontation is to promote reconciliation between the parties: If the wrongdoer listens to the victim, then the victim will gain a brother.

Let's briefly return to the story of the unforgiving servant (Matthew 6:23-35). What could the unforgiving servant have done to confront his debtor without angering his king?

First, he could have confronted his fellow-servant in private. (*Cf.* Matthew 6:28.) Second, he could have been cordial to his fellow-servant instead of wringing his neck. (*Cf.* v. 28.) Then if his fellow-servant had still said, "Have patience with me, and I will pay thee all," the unforgiving servant could have given him a break. If he had behaved this way, the original servant might have been repaid without jeopardizing his pardon from the king.

Reconciliation implies a balancing of equities, does it not? When an accountant reconciles a spreadsheet, numbers are added to the debit ledger (or to the credit ledger) so that both sides will equal. Likewise, if one confronts another Christian with the latter's wrongdoing, true reconciliation cannot happen unless the malefactor makes (or at least promises to make) restitution to the victim.

In simple matters, such as a minor spat between spouses or siblings or close friends, a simple "I'm sorry" or "please forgive me" will often suffice as restitution. However, in situations where money is lost, where property is damaged, or where persons are injured, a more serious attempt at restitution will likely be required. When believers are involved in such situations, the wrongdoer should offer compensation when confronted by the victim. By doing so, the wrongdoer is demonstrating his desire to restore the relationship to where it had been before the commission of the wrongful act.

Sometimes, though, a wrongdoer will not believe he has done anything wrong. In these instances, Jesus commands the victim to go an extra step—to present his case before the malefactor, this time with one or two witnesses (v. 16).

Under the Old Testament law, one could not bring suit before Moses unless he had two or three witnesses, counting himself, to corroborate his claim of wrongdoing.

(See Deuteronomy 19:15.) Here, Jesus invokes this very language. By instructing a victim to confront the wrongdoer privately with one or two additional witnesses, Jesus is implying that the victim should send the proverbial shot across the wrongdoer's bow. The presentation of two or three witnesses, counting the victim, would indicate to the offender that further action will be taken unless reconciliation is had, and by extension, restitution is made.

As we know, there are some really stubborn people in the world. Such persons, even when confronted with the victim's case, may still ignore reason. In such instances, the victim is *commanded* to bring the matter to the attention of the church (v. 17). By bringing his case to the church, the victim invites the scrutiny of other believers.

If the church thinks that the victim has a valid case, the church will confront the offender. At this point, the offender will have a choice. Will he listen to the spiritual authority that God has placed over him? Or will the offender reject this authority?

If the offender listens to the church, he will presumably repent of the wrongdoing and make restitution to his brother or sister. However, if the offender fails to listen to the church, Jesus *commands* the victim to treat the offender as if he were a heathen or a publican. In other words, Jesus commands the victim to cut all ties with the offender.

Keep in mind that the purpose for this confrontation has less to do with the victim's need for restitution and more to do with the wrongdoer's need for correction. Unless an offender is given the opportunity to repent, he will not repent. Of course, if the wrongdoer is a Christian, there is always the possibility that the Holy Spirit will bring conviction to the person, prompting the offender to approach the victim unilaterally to make restitution. (See Matthew 5:23-24.) On the other hand, the Holy Spirit may desire to bring conviction to the offender by using the victim to address the

situation. If so, it is imperative for the victim to obey the Scripture on this subject.

As a practical matter, however, most churches do not make themselves available for dispute resolution. Furthermore, given the number of different congregations that are present in even the smallest of communities, there would be a greater chance that a victim and an offending party would attend different churches—assuming they both attend church at all—than the same congregation. Therefore, to comply with this provision, one may find it necessary to recruit a group of neutral believers to hear the matter.

Either way, if one cannot find a Christian group to hear the matter, or if the alleged malefactor refuses to submit to mediation before an available body, I believe the victim has done everything in his power to comply with both the spirit and the letter of this ordinance. The victim may then treat the wrongdoer as if he were a non-believer.

This brings us to our next point. What if the wrongdoer is not a Christian?

Depending upon the circumstances, a victim may have three basic options. First, the victim may select to use the method for dispute resolution that is set forth in the afore-said passage, even though the wrongdoer is not a Christian. Then again, the victim may choose to jump straight to the part where he cuts all ties with the wrongdoer. (The victim is, after all, under no obligation to comply with the passage since it pertains only to disputes between Christians.) Lastly, if the damage done is quite severe, the victim may contemplate litigation.

Speaking of litigation, for centuries, legal (and even theological) scholars have used certain canons of statutory construction to interpret various texts. One such canon is stated in Latin as “*expressio unius est exclusio alterius*,” which means, “the expression of the one is the exclusion of the other.”³⁹ In layman’s terms, this canon means that if

a certain rule prohibits a particular action, then insofar as this rule is concerned, all other actions are implied to be permitted. (For example, if a child is expressly prohibited from playing in the street, unless and until his mother or father says otherwise, he is implied to have the right to play in the front yard.)

In light of this, let's examine I Corinthians 6:1-7:

Dare any of you, having a matter against another, go to law before the unjust, and not before the saints? (v. 1)

Do ye not know that the saints shall judge the world? and if the world shall be judged by you, are ye unworthy to judge the smallest matters? (v. 2)

Know ye not that we shall judge angels? how much more things that pertain to this life? (v. 3)

If then ye have judgments of things pertaining to this life, set them to judge who are least esteemed in the church. (v. 4)

I speak to your shame. Is it so, that there is not a wise man among you? no, not one that shall be able to judge between his brethren? (v. 5)

But brother goeth to law with brother, and that before the unbelievers. (v. 6)

Now therefore there is utterly a fault among you, because ye go to law one with another. Why do ye not rather take wrong? why do ye not rather suffer yourselves to be defrauded? (v. 7)

Here, the Apostle Paul commands Christians not to bring lawsuits against each other—at least not in a secular court. Instead, Paul encourages believers to find someone in the church—even a person of low esteem—to serve as a judge over their disputes. With regard to disputes between a believer and a non-believer, however, Paul is silent.

Therefore, if we use the aforementioned canon to interpret this passage, we may surmise that while a Christian is generally prohibited from bringing suit against another Christian, by negative implication, a Christian would *not* be prohibited from suing a non-Christian in a secular court.

Taking this a step further, if the wrongdoer is a Christian who has rejected the spiritual authority of the Church (*see* Matthew 18:20), then Paul's prohibition against suing fellow believers would not apply (unless it would still bring reproach to the church). Even though the offender may be a believer, we have been commanded to treat the wrongdoer as if he were a heathen and a publican. (*See id.*) Thus, any immunity from litigation that would normally be associated with his Christian faith would now be of no benefit to the wrongdoer who has rejected the authority of the Church.

In short, if you have a dispute against a Christian, the path to forgiveness necessitates that you confront your brother or sister in the manner set forth in Matthew 18. If this method fails, or if you are dealing with a non-Christian, then litigation is still on the table.

Before I go any further, I want to make something clear. *If you think that there exists even the most remote possibility that you will have to sue someone else, please contact a Christian attorney before you follow the steps set forth in Matthew 18.* As an attorney, myself, I understand that what you say to a potential defendant out of court may be used against you later. If litigation is possible, you will need the help of a Christian attorney licensed in your home state. He

will advise you as to what you should say and how you should say it as you follow the steps set forth in Matthew 18.

If litigation does, in fact, remain on the table, when should a Christian sue? Lots of factors fit into this equation. First and foremost, the Christian should ascertain whether this is a matter for which our courts would normally be involved. Generally, this determination can be made from the extent of one's damages. For example, if there has been, or stands to be, loss of life, health, property, money, employment, or reputation, then courts would generally be interested in such a matter. Likewise, courts would generally be interested in situations pertaining to domestic relations, divorce, the treatment of children or the elderly and disabled, and the like. Check with a licensed attorney to see if your situation would be one for the courts to examine.

Assuming that the matter is indeed something for which a court would assume jurisdiction, the next step is for the victim to consult an attorney licensed in his home state to determine the applicable statute of limitations for this offense. A statute of limitations is a law passed by the state legislature (or the Congress, as the case may be) that limits the time in which a victim can file suit. Since this period varies from jurisdiction to jurisdiction, and from subject matter to subject matter, a victim must contact an attorney as soon as possible to determine his rights.

The victim should also discuss the relative merits of his case with the attorney. Litigation is very expensive and time consuming. In my brief career as an attorney, I have already witnessed situations where clients have spent more in attorneys' fees than they ever received in judgment or settlement. Even when the client is warned in advance that he may lose more money fighting than he would likely gain by winning, the client still gets mad at the attorney when the costs exceed the reward.

Naturally, this is quite understandable when one considers that most people who sue for the sake of “principle” are really seeking after revenge. Embittered by the initial wrong, they want to fight and fight and fight until they squeeze the last ounce of life from their enemies. Then when they leave the courthouse in defeat, or with less of a victory than was expected, they tend to become embittered at their lawyers.

In the final analysis, Christians should only commence litigation when they can say without equivocation that they are not doing so out of revenge or greed, but rather out of necessity. If a Christian needs a remedy that only the courts can provide, or if a believer wants to prevent a person from committing the same wrong to someone else, then litigation is necessary. However, if a Christian’s motivation is to “get back” at the wrongdoer or, perhaps, simply to make a fast buck, then such a person needs to reexamine his heart before filing suit.

At the end of the day, a vindictive person will always lose more by fighting than he could have possibly gained from winning. In addition to limiting one’s access to God’s favor, grace and mercy, a bitter person will also step off the Godly Path of Least Resistance.

Chapter
SEVENTH SEMESTER:
“AND LEAD US NOT INTO TEMPTATION”



Since this book deals with the avoidance of temptation, one might have surmised that this is the most important chapter of this book. In fact, one might have skipped ahead to this chapter hoping to cut to the chase. If so, one will need a quick review of what we have covered thus far.

We have learned that God is our Heavenly Father. God has only our best intentions at heart, even though His best and our best may not always coincide. Because of His infinite, yet objective love, God deserves to be respected. His Name deserves to be exalted, even at the expense of our own reputations.

His infinite love, His supreme objectivity, and His exalted reputation make God worthy to be our King. He is, after all, the only Being capable of bringing absolute peace and harmony to the fallen world in which we live. Accordingly, His Kingdom should expand until it covers every nook and cranny of the planet, until every heart and mind has submitted to the Plan and Purpose of God the Father through Jesus Christ our Lord. As God's Kingdom expands, so shall His control expand. As God takes greater control, His Will shall be done on Earth even as it is in Heaven.

With God in control, we should look to Him to provide our daily bread. We should look to God for anything that we need for day-to-day survival. However, we must keep in mind that God is not going to weigh us down with too much provision at any given time. After all, He would not want to undermine the development of our character by blessing us with too much, too fast. Instead, God desires to be our periodic source for our periodic needs. To borrow from the world of engineering, God wants to be our just-in-time supplier.

When a person realizes that God will provide for his needs (spiritual, emotional and physical) in a timely and efficient manner, such a one will become more secure in his faith. Such a person will have a greater sense of perspective. When offenses come—when material possessions are stolen, or when friends withdraw their validation, or when plans fall through—he will be less inclined to harbor resentment or to seek revenge. Instead, like Job, he will say “Naked came I out of my mother’s womb, and naked shall I return thither: the Lord gave, and the Lord hath taken away; blessed be the name of the Lord.” (Job 1:21)

We need God’s grace more than we need air to breathe or water to drink. Fortunately, God wants to demonstrate His favor in our lives; He wants to give us this grace. However, as the Supreme Arbiter of Objective Truth, God will not extend His grace toward a person who is unforgiving. Indeed, if there is any aspect of a person’s character that could lead to a spirit of unforgiveness, God can (and will) do whatever is necessary to root this out of such a one’s life. After all, being the gracious fellow that He is, God wants us to follow in His footsteps.

This, of course, brings us to the ultimate premise of this volume. The Lord’s Prayer is a roadmap for our lives. Quite literally, if we follow the simple plan that has been set forth in the Model Prayer, we will adopt the very character traits that God is hoping to find in our lives. However, like any

other roadmap, each step in this prayer must be mastered before the next level can be achieved.

Thus, if we do not wish for God to lead us into temptation, then we must (1) become secure in His objective love for us, (2) subordinate our need for validation to His desire to be praised, (3) cede all power and authority over our lives to Him, (4) trust Him for all of our needs, and (5) learn how to forgive each other. Only then may we pray in “faith, nothing wavering” (James 1:6) for God to “lead us not into temptation.”

The Bible teaches that Jesus “was in all points tempted like as we are, yet without sin.” (Hebrews 4:15) Logic dictates that if Jesus was tempted in every possible way, then it would be impossible for us to face any temptation other than what Jesus Himself encountered.

Granted, Jesus never experienced the *precise* temptations that people face today. Obviously, He was never tempted to download pornography from the internet. Likewise, I can find no instance in Scripture where Jesus was tempted to purchase crystal meth from the back of a full-size van. Be that as it may, the temptations that Jesus experienced 2,000 years ago have been repackaged into each and every temptation that we face today. As King Solomon has stated, “The thing that hath been, it is that which shall be; and that which is done is that which shall be done: and there is no new thing under the sun.” (Ecclesiastes 1:9)

Every temptation—including those that seem unique to our generation—may be traced to our natural human desires (1) for gratification, (2) for control, and (3) for validation. We understand this because the only record of Jesus being tempted was in these three areas. (Although Jesus was tempted to harbor unforgiveness as He hung on the cross, this temptation was derived from these three areas; the crucifixion deprived Jesus of all gratification, validation, and control. Likewise, the same may be said of Jesus’ suffering

at Gethsemane.) Since these were the only areas that Jesus faced temptation, these will be the only areas in which we will face temptation.

Let us now examine Matthew 4:

Then was Jesus led up of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted of the devil. (v. 1)

And when he had fasted forty days and forty nights, he was afterward an hungered. (v. 2)

And when the tempter came to him, he said, If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread. (v. 3)

But he answered and said, It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God. (v. 4)

Then the devil taketh him up into the holy city, and setteth him on a pinnacle of the temple, (v. 5)

And saith unto him, If thou be the Son of God, cast thyself down: for it is written, He shall give his angels charge concerning thee: and in their hands they shall bear thee up, lest at any time thou dash thy foot against a stone. (v. 6)

Jesus said unto him, It is written again, Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God. (v. 7)

Again, the devil taketh him up into an exceeding high mountain, and sheweth him all the kingdoms of the world, and the glory of them; (v 8)

And saith unto him, All these things will I give thee, if thou wilt fall down and worship me. (v. 9)

Then saith Jesus unto him, Get thee hence, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve. (v. 10)

Then the devil leaveth him, and, behold, angels came and ministered unto him. (v. 11)

We observe from this passage that Jesus had fasted for forty days and forty nights. Now, there exists some debate as to whether the temptation period covered forty literal days and forty literal nights, or whether the phrase “forty days and forty nights” was simply a euphemism for an indefinitely long period.⁴⁰ Either way, by the time Jesus had gone “forty days and forty nights” without food, He was hungry. Suffice it to say, Jesus desperately needed to be gratified.

We may also glean from the account of Mark that Jesus was alone, completely isolated from human contact. Mark states that Jesus “was with the wild beasts.” (Mark 1:13) The fact that a beast is wild implies that it has not been tamed by humans. Since untamed animals have been known to kill defenseless persons, such wild beasts generally do not cohabit with people. Thus, we may conclude that Jesus was taken to a remote place, far from the influence of society. Moreover, since no other human is mentioned in any account of Jesus’ temptations, we may surmise that Jesus was alone (except, of course, for the devil, the wild beasts and the ministering angels.) Therefore, Jesus was deprived not only of food, but also of validation and support from His friends and family.

The Bible states that Jesus was in the wilderness. When I think of a wilderness, the first thought that crosses my mind is of a rich forest ripe with flourishing vegetation. I envision birds perching on lofty tree limbs. I can also imagine deer

drinking from a small brook. However, such is not the type of wilderness in which Jesus traversed.

No, this was a hot, Middle Eastern desert with miles of rocks and sand. Although there had to be some vegetation to sustain the wild beasts living in this region, for all intents and purposes, Jesus could see few, if any, trees or plants. Hence the reason the devil tempted Him to turn a stone into bread. Without trees to cut and to shape, this young carpenter had little, if any, material upon which to exercise dominion.

In the final analysis, Jesus was in a place of utter depravation. His physical needs were unmet. He could exercise little control over His environment. Without human interaction, He lacked personal validation.

Now, before we can fully examine each of the temptations that Jesus faced, we must juxtapose Matthew's account with the narrative set forth in Luke 4:

And Jesus being full of the Holy Ghost returned from Jordan, and was led by the Spirit into the wilderness, (v. 1)

Being forty days tempted of the devil. And in those days he did eat nothing: and when they were ended, he afterward hungered. (v. 2)

And the devil said unto him, If thou be the Son of God, command this stone that it be made bread. (v. 3)

And Jesus answered him, saying, It is written, That man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word of God. (v. 4)

And the devil, taking him up into an high mountain, shewed unto him all the kingdoms of the world in a moment of time. (v. 5)

And the devil said unto him, All this power will I give thee, and the glory of them: for that is delivered unto me; and to whomsoever I will I give it. (v. 6)

If thou therefore wilt worship me, all shall be thine. (v. 7)

And Jesus answered and said unto him, Get thee behind me, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve. (v. 8)

And he brought him to Jerusalem, and set him on a pinnacle of the temple, and said unto him, If thou be the Son of God, cast thyself down from hence: (v. 9)

For it is written, He shall give his angels charge over thee, to keep thee: (v. 10)

And in their hands they shall bear thee up, lest at any time thou dash thy foot against a stone. (v. 11)

And Jesus answering said unto him, It is said, Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God. (v. 12)

And when the devil had ended all the temptation, he departed from him for a season. (v. 13)

Both Matthew and Luke describe the same temptations. However, the chronology is different in each account. Although both accounts begin with the temptation to turn a

stone into bread, Matthew and Luke reverse the order of the remaining two temptations. Matthew lists the temptation to jump off the temple before he describes the temptation to worship the devil. The reverse holds for Luke's account.

Until a few years ago, I wondered why the temptations were listed in different orders. Was this some sort of discrepancy? Did Matthew or Luke make a mistake in chronicling these events?

Being one who believes that the Bible is the infallible Word of God, I could not support the position that these passages contradicted one another. Then again, my logical mind could not deny that if *A* happened before *B*, then *B* could not have preceded *A*.

To reconcile this conundrum, I concluded that neither Matthew nor Luke had warranted the chronology of their respective accounts. Instead, I reasoned that Matthew and Luke had simply recounted Jesus' temptations in the order of their relative importance, and not in the order of their occurrence.

I concluded that there was a hierarchy of temptation. Because both Matthew and Luke list the temptation to turn a stone into bread as the first temptation, I reasoned that Matthew and Luke each believed that this particular temptation should be set apart from the other two. Conversely, because Matthew and Luke list the two remaining temptations in different orders of importance, I further surmised that these temptations were, for all intents and purposes, interchangeable. So while the temptation to turn a stone to bread was in a class by itself, the two remaining temptations should be grouped together.

Although both writers list the temptation to turn the stone into bread first, I shall discuss this temptation last. In the meantime, we should examine the temptation to jump off the Temple. (For the sake of consistency, I shall now refer exclusively to Matthew's account.)

The Temptation to Jump From the Temple (Matthew 4:5-7)

Then the devil taketh him up into the holy city, and setteth him on a pinnacle of the temple, (v. 5)

And saith unto him, If thou be the Son of God, cast thyself down: for it is written, He shall give his angels charge concerning thee: and in their hands they shall bear thee up, lest at any time thou dash thy foot against a stone. (v. 6)

Jesus said unto him, It is written again, Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God. (v. 7)

The nineteenth-century theologian Charles Deems explains this temptation in his 1882 volume, *The Light of the Nations*. As Deems puts it, the temptation to jump off the Temple was not a ploy to convince Jesus to fall to His death. Instead, it was designed to get Jesus to reveal His Messianic claim prematurely.⁴¹

The Temple was the center of Jewish religion and custom. Day-in and day-out, faithful followers of the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob would come to the Temple to pray for the Messiah to deliver them from the Romans and to reestablish the Throne of David. In light of this, if Jesus had jumped from the Temple and had floated safely to the ground by the assistance of the holy angels, even the Pharisees would have dropped to their knees in reverential worship.

It's no wonder then that Satan prefaced his temptation with the taunt, "If thou be the Son of God." (Matthew 4:6; Luke 4:9) Indeed, if Jesus had wanted to prove to the world that He was the Son of God, this would have been the easy way out. Instead of having to suffer an ignominious death on a cruel Roman cross, He could have simply jumped from

the Temple and revealed His Glory. The Jews would have immediately crowned Jesus king, and like the Maccabeans, they would have revolted against their Gentile oppressors.⁴²

Of course, if Jesus had done this, the Father's plan for human redemption would have fallen apart. Yes, Jesus would have experienced the praise and adulation of countless thousands of people. Yes, Jesus would have likely been able to conquer the Roman Empire (as well as the rest of the world). Yes, the world would have been a better place if Jesus had revealed His glory. However, humanity could never have been reconciled with God.

If Jesus had jumped from the Temple, the angels likely would have caught Him. The crowds would have worshipped Him. He would have been crowned King. However, Jesus would have chosen the good at the expense of the best. He would have compromised God's perfect plan, and Satan's ultimate defeat, in order to receive the immediate validation of His people.

If He had done this, He would have stepped out of God's perfect plan. By doing so, He would have tempted God. Since it was written in the Law that "thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God," Jesus would have sinned if He had jumped from the Temple. (Come to think of it, by sinning, He might have even lost the right to be caught by the angels.)

Now think about it for just a moment. Jesus has gone "forty days and forty nights" without even a hint of human interaction. Like all human beings, He wanted validation; being the Messiah, He certainly deserved it. Nevertheless when given the choice of (a) obtaining the validation that He both wanted and deserved, or (b) submitting to the Plan and Purposes of His Heavenly Father, Jesus chose the latter. He understood that validation from God is far more important than validation from man.

The temptation to worship the devil is much easier to understand. Unlike the temptation to jump off the Temple,

this one needs no historical context. The offer was straight-up: Satan promised to give Jesus control of the kingdoms of the world in exchange for Jesus' allegiance to Satan. The account is as follows:

The Temptation to Worship the Devil (Matthew 4:8-10)

Again, the devil taketh him up into an exceeding high mountain, and sheweth him all the kingdoms of the world, and the glory of them; (v 8)

And saith unto him, All these things will I give thee, if thou wilt fall down and worship me. (v. 9)

Then saith Jesus unto him, Get thee hence, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve. (v. 10)

Most of us have never been deprived of complete control over our environments. So it is hard for us to imagine exactly how much pressure Jesus was under at the time.

On the one hand, Jesus was the Messiah. He was the only begotten Son of God. He was entitled to live like a Prince and to rule and reign. Naturally, He desired to rule over the kingdoms of the world. It was, after all, His destiny.

However, Jesus knew that His Father's Plan involved three years of sorrow and rejection culminating with a shameful public execution at the hands of the Romans. By worshipping the devil, Jesus could have become king of the world, and by extension, He could have earned the adulation and praise of all the inhabitants of planet Earth.

As armchair quarterbacks, we may read this passage and see just how foolish it would have been for Jesus to worship the devil. Satan, after all, is not known for his integrity. We know (or at least we should know) that if Jesus had dropped

to his knees and praised the devil, Jesus would have not only sinned against His Father, but He would have been cheated. The devil would have triumphed, and no one—not even Jesus—could have required him to keep his promise.

Be that as it may, we must recognize that Jesus had been deprived of all control over His environment for a very long time. Surely this depravation, coupled with extreme hunger, made Satan's offer quite alluring. Nevertheless, Jesus had enough strength of character not to sin against the Father. Although Jesus desired to be King, He desired even more to be right with His Father.

The temptations to jump off the Temple and to worship the devil were interchangeable in that they would have both achieved the same ends. If Jesus had floated safely to the ground after jumping from the highest point of the Temple, He would have been praised by the people, and then He would have been crowned king. Conversely, if Jesus had become king of the world after worshipping the devil, humanity would have eventually dropped to their knees in adoration. Either way, Jesus would have enjoyed both validation and control. In effect, the temptations were two sides of the same coin.

Now let us shift to the first temptation, *i.e.*, the temptation to turn the stone into bread.

The Temptation to Turn the Stone to Bread (Matthew 4:2-4)

And when he had fasted forty days and forty nights, he was afterward an hungered. (v. 2)

And when the tempter came to him, he said, If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread. (v. 3)

But he answered and said, It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God. (v. 4)

What separates this temptation from the other two is that, for all practical purposes, this was not a temptation to commit sin, *per se*.

Unlike the other two temptations, where the acts in question were expressly prohibited by Scripture, the Old Testament is silent as to the subject of turning stones to bread. Nowhere in the Bible does it say, “Thou shalt not turn a stone into bread.” Therefore, if Jesus had, in fact, turned the stone to bread, He would not have sinned.

Well if that is the case, then why was it a temptation? Better yet, why didn’t Jesus perform this feat and eat?

To answer these questions, we must ascertain what this temptation has in common with the other two.

Obviously, this temptation has to do with affecting change upon the material world. If Jesus had, in fact, turned a stone into bread, He would have exercised no small amount of power and authority. By manipulating his environment to satisfy his needs, Jesus would have acted just like an earthly king (minus, of course, the supernatural element of transforming stones to bread). Although His only subject would have been an inanimate rock, and not millions of people, He still would have been gratified simply by giving a command. Plus, His bidding would have been accomplished at once.

As such, we can see a nexus between the temptation to turn a stone to bread and the temptation to worship the devil. Both temptations played upon Jesus’ desire to exercise control over His environment. In the former temptation, Jesus’ attention was directed to a lifeless rock. In the latter temptation, His focus broadened to the entire world and to every person living thereupon. In essence, the temptation to turn the stone to bread was a microcosm of the temptation

to worship the devil as both temptations played upon Jesus' desire to rule and reign.

Likewise, the temptation to turn the stone to bread is intertwined with the temptation to jump off the Temple. In both temptations, Satan said, "If thou be the Son of God." Clearly, Satan was playing upon Jesus' desire for personal validation.

By tempting Jesus to turn the stone to bread, Satan essentially was saying, "Prove to *me* that you are Messiah." By tempting Jesus to jump off the Temple, Satan was saying, "Prove to the *world* that you are Messiah."

Think back to your childhood for just a moment. Did your friends at school or your neighbors ever dare you to perform a certain feat that you didn't want to do? For example, did your friends ever dare you to climb a tall tree—one that you had never attempted to climb?

My childhood friends typically had three general responses to any such dare. Usually, the kid being dared would say, "I can if I want to, but I don't want to." Of course, the instigators would automatically assume that the child was lying. So they would pressure the child incessantly until the child responded with either (a) "OK, I'm going home,"—which really meant, "I'm chicken"—or (b) "I'll show you."

When Jesus was tempted to turn the stone to bread, going home to Daddy was not an option. Instead, when Satan used this temptation to question Jesus' relationship with God, metaphorically speaking, Jesus had two possible responses: (a) "I can if I want to, but I don't want to," or (b) "I'll show you."

In so many words, Jesus chose the former. However, this temptation must have gotten on Jesus' nerves. Although Jesus was the Son of God, He was still a flesh and blood human being. Certainly, He wanted to prove to the devil, the biggest bully in the Universe, that He (Jesus) was the Son of God. If Jesus had turned the stone to bread, then surely the

devil would have been forced to admit that Jesus was the Son of God. Right?

Maybe not. When bullies dare other children to perform certain tasks, sometimes the children being dared actually achieve their objectives. Sometimes the child who is dared to climb the tall tree actually climbs the tree. Usually when this happens, the bully is not satisfied. Instead of applauding the child who performed the dare for a job well-done, the bully often responds by raising the bar higher. “You think this tree is big,” the bully exclaims, “try and climb that tree.” Like a poker player whose bluff has just been called, the bully will raise the stakes until either the other player goes “all in” or folds.

If Jesus had responded favorably to Satan’s temptation to turn the stone to bread, the Lord certainly would have experienced some degree of satisfaction in knowing that Satan had been proven wrong. However, such exhilaration would have been short-lived. The devil would have simply disparaged Jesus’ miracle and then, like a swine in possession of pearls, Satan would have attacked Jesus yet again—tempting Him this time to jump off the Temple. The Lord very well could have overcome this temptation even if He had turned the stone to bread; however, it would have been more difficult. If Jesus had been unable to resist the temptation to “convince” Satan of His messianic claim, Jesus would have likely been unable to resist the temptation to “convince” the Temple worshipers that He was Messiah.

Even if Jesus had overcome the temptation to demonstrate His Divinity by jumping off the Temple, He still would have been hard-pressed to resist the temptation to jump off the cross as He was taunted by passers-by. “If thou be the Son of God,” these people jeered, “come down from the cross.” (Matthew 27:40)

Of course, Jesus didn’t fail in either respect. His success was due in no small measure to His decision not to turn the

stone to bread. Jesus understood that if He couldn't handle small challenges, He would be unable to accomplish bigger feats. As Jeremiah observed: "If thou hast run with the footmen, and they have wearied thee, then how canst thou contend with horses? and if in the land of peace, wherein thou trustedst, they wearied thee, then how wilt thou do in the swelling of Jordan?" (Jeremiah 12:5)

Although the temptation to turn the stone to bread was not a temptation to commit sin, *per se*, it was by far the most important of the three temptations. For if Jesus had succumb to the devil's prodding to turn this rock into much-needed food, our Lord would have demonstrated a weakness. Jesus would have shown that He could not completely restrain his desire for control and/or validation. Thus, Satan could have gleaned right then and there that even Jesus had a price. The devil would have only needed to figure out how much it was.

Fortunately, Jesus didn't fall for this temptation. Instead, Jesus identified His situation with that of His ancestors. By doing so, Jesus demonstrated that He had the proper perspective to bring Him through this trial with flying colors.

In response to Satan's temptation to turn the stone to bread, Jesus replied, "It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God." (Matthew 4:4). Jesus was quoting from Deuteronomy 8:3. The entire chapter is listed below (with emphasis added):

All the commandments which I command thee this day shall ye observe to do, that ye may live, and multiply, and go in and possess the land which the LORD sware unto your fathers. (v. 1)

And thou shalt remember all the way which the LORD thy God led thee these forty years in the wilderness.

to humble thee, and to prove thee, to know what was in thine heart, whether thou wouldest keep his commandments, or no. (v. 2)

And he humbled thee, and suffered thee to hunger, and fed thee with manna, which thou knewest not, neither did thy fathers know; that he might make thee know that man doth not live by bread only, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of the LORD doth man live. (v. 3)

Thy raiment waxed not old upon thee, neither did thy foot swell, these forty years. (v. 4)

Thou shalt also consider in thine heart, that, as a man chasteneth his son, so the LORD thy God chasteneth thee. (v. 5)

Therefore thou shalt keep the commandments of the LORD thy God, to walk in his ways, and to fear him. (v. 6)

For the LORD thy God bringeth thee into a good land, a land of brooks of water, of fountains and depths that spring out of valleys and hills; (v. 7)

A land of wheat, and barley, and vines, and fig trees, and pomegranates; a land of oil olive, and honey; (v. 8)

A land wherein thou shalt eat bread without scarceness, thou shalt not lack any thing in it; a land whose stones are iron, and out of whose hills thou mayest dig brass. (v. 9)

When thou hast eaten and art full, then thou shalt bless the LORD thy God for the good land which he hath given thee. (v. 10)

Beware that thou forget not the LORD thy God, in not keeping his commandments, and his judgments, and his statutes, which I command thee this day: (v. 11)

Lest when thou hast eaten and art full, and hast built goodly houses, and dwelt therein; (v. 12)

And when thy herds and thy flocks multiply, and thy silver and thy gold is multiplied, and all that thou hast is multiplied; (v. 13)

Then thine heart be lifted up, and thou forget the LORD thy God, which brought thee forth out of the land of Egypt, from the house of bondage; (v. 14)

Who led thee through that great and terrible wilderness, wherein were fiery serpents, and scorpions, and drought, where there was no water; who brought thee forth water out of the rock of flint; (v. 15)

Who fed thee in the wilderness with manna, which thy fathers knew not, that he might humble thee, and that he might prove thee, to do thee good at thy latter end; (v. 16)

And thou say in thine heart, My power and the might of mine hand hath gotten me this wealth. (v. 17)

But thou shalt remember the LORD thy God: for it is he that giveth thee power to get wealth, that he

may establish his covenant which he sware unto thy fathers, as it is this day. (v. 18)

And it shall be, if thou do at all forget the LORD thy God, and walk after other gods, and serve them, and worship them, I testify against you this day that ye shall surely perish. (v. 19)

As the nations which the LORD destroyeth before your face, so shall ye perish; because ye would not be obedient unto the voice of the LORD your God. (v. 20)

It was no accident that Jesus chose a verse from this passage to respond to the temptation to turn the stone into bread. The similarities between Jesus' tribulation and that of the ancient Israelites are patently obvious.

First, Jesus and the Israelites both wandered in the wilderness (perhaps even the same geography). Second, the length of their respective temptations was forty units of time, to wit: Jesus suffered for forty days, whereas the Israelites suffered for forty years. Third, Jesus and the Israelites were deprived of food.

In addition, Jesus and the Israelites faced the same spiritual temptations. The Israelites tempted God (*see, e.g.,* Exodus 17:7, Numbers 14:22, and Psalm 78) and they worshipped idols (Exodus 32). These acts mirror the precise temptations that Jesus faced in the wilderness.

These temptations are also reflected in Deuteronomy 8. A person who thinks, "My power and the might of mine hand hath gotten me this wealth," (v. 17), will likely feel the inclination to step out of God's Plan and jump off the proverbial Temple. Likewise, a person who forgets the Lord and focuses solely upon material possessions will be inclined to follow after other gods (*see* v. 19) and perhaps even to

worship the devil himself in order to obtain greater control of the world around him.

Jesus recognized that there was, indeed, a purpose for not only His time in the wilderness, but also for the dry times that we all must endure. Jesus understood that when a person undergoes testing, it is not because the person has been abandoned by God. Instead, it is because God is taking a closer look at the person's character.

In the same way that a business owner would conduct a background check on a prospective employee—by asking detailed questions, by contacting job references, or by running a credit check—so will God humble us and prove us in order to learn what is in our hearts. (*See* v. 2.)

Before God will entrust us with any measure of responsibility, He must discern whether we will obey His commandments. He needs to prove us (*see* v. 16). He needs for us to understand exactly who the boss is.

He is not going to cast His pearls to swine. (*See* Matthew 7.) He is not going to give a person the full measure of His Power and Anointing without first ascertaining whether the person in question is capable of handling it. (*See* Chapter Four, *supra*.) Likewise, He is not going to bless us with any measure of prosperity or material blessing until He is satisfied that we are free of any notion that we are capable of achieving such success in our own strength. Rather, He will only pour His grace and mercy into a vessel that has been pressure-tested.

This explains why so many people miss out on what God has planned for their lives. When Christians enter wilderness experiences, where they are deprived of validation, control or gratification for an extended period of time, they tend to drop to their knees and pray for God to deliver them from their problems. Of course, there is nothing wrong with praying for deliverance; indeed, the next chapter focuses upon this subject. However, one must never forget that the lessons of

the Model Prayer are sequential: Before one can pray for deliverance, one must first master the lessons found in the previous sections of the Prayer—*i.e.*, security, humility, submission to God, contentment, and forgiveness. If one is lacking in any of these areas, then instead of praying for a change of scenery, one needs to pray for a change of heart.

Several years ago, my wife and I experienced severe financial difficulty. Although our situation was uncomfortable to say the least, I can now look back and see just how God spared us from the worst. Today, I recognize just how the Lord was leading me through the wilderness, away from the fiery scorpions and serpents and drought (*see* Deuteronomy 8:15). By His grace, we didn't have to file for bankruptcy, even though we very well could have. Nor did we ever have anything more serious than "thirty-day late" notations placed upon our respective credit reports (though we did have several of them).

Back then, I didn't have the perspective that I now have. At the time, I worked for the Oral Roberts Evangelistic Association ("OREA") in Tulsa, Oklahoma—the city known by some as being the "Charismatic Jerusalem." While working at OREA (which, by the way, is a fine organization where some of my dearest friends work), I regularly attended services where Oral Roberts, Kenneth Copeland, Jesse Duplantis, and other like-minded preachers would teach. Hardly, a month or two would pass without a celebrated speaker coming to town.

Now, for the reader who is unfamiliar with the prosperity message, its proponents teach that God wants to bless His people with material wealth and blessings. To become eligible for God's blessings, these ministers (including the aforesaid speakers) teach that we must give generously to the work of the Gospel and believe that God will bless us in return.

Now, my purpose in mentioning this is not to criticize this doctrine. The fact is, I also believe that God wants to bless His people. Nevertheless, my experiences have given me a different perspective on the topic.

When my wife and I walked through our wilderness nearly a decade ago, we became so focused—so consumed—with our financial lack that we viewed our poverty as if it were a prison. Like all prisoners, we wanted a reprieve of some sort. We prayed. We fasted. We did everything that we could to break the chains of poverty on our lives.

Little did we realize, however, that we were merely trying to turn a stone into bread.

Instead of waiting on the Lord—instead of attempting to discern God’s perspective on our situation—we assumed that having money was the ultimate solution to all of our problems. With money, we could settle down, build (or buy) a house, expand our family, and then—maybe, just maybe—we could pursue the dreams that God had placed in our hearts.

Mercifully, God did not answer our prayers for money—at least not so quickly. Instead, the Lord used my struggle to inspire me to go to law school. Providing scholarship money and student loans, God allowed me to study at Regent University School of Law in Virginia Beach, Virginia. At Regent, I learned a great deal about the Bible, and I grew in the Lord by no small measure. In fact, much of this volume is derived from my studies at Regent. From there, God directed me to return to my home state, and then later, to the town where my wife and I had attended college a decade earlier.

In the meantime, God has blessed us with daily provision, meeting our needs consistently and regularly. In fact, our credit scores have improved to the point where we may now purchase another house, if we so desire.

The point is, if God had allowed me to prosper financially at the wrong time, I would have never moved according

to His Plan. I would have stayed in Oklahoma. I probably would not have gone to law school—or if I had, I would have likely missed the opportunity to attend a Christian law school where the Bible is actually taught in class.

Further, if God had allowed me to turn the stone into bread, I would have been susceptible to the temptation to seek validation or control in the wrong way. Rather than pursuing God's Plan, I would have pursued mine, likely repeating the same mistakes that had gotten me into the wilderness in the first place. Just as I had done when I attempted to sell life insurance (after God had expressly told me not to), I likely would have pursued another failed venture—not because I would have lacked intelligence or even wisdom, but because I was so desperate for validation and control that I would have jumped ahead of God.

I wanted the validation that came from being successful, from having my friends and family say that I had actually made something of myself. To me, being in poverty was less about being out of control, and more about bearing the shame of failure. I truly believe that if God had blessed me financially before He had a chance to remove, at least, some of this insecurity, I would have taken His prosperity and blown it—just as Jesus would have done if He had jumped from the Temple. I would have attempted to bite off something too big for me to chew.

Instead, God used the time in the wilderness to teach me some important lessons. He taught me that He loved me no matter what. He taught me that I needed to respect Him for who He is. He taught me that He needed to be in complete control of my life. He taught me how to be contented. He taught me how to be merciful and gracious to those who have made big mistakes of their own. Essentially, I learned to trust Him more and to judge others less.

Of course, if I had simply gleaned this from the Lord's Prayer, then I could have prayed, "Lead me not into temp-

tation” with some measure of credibility. If God had been satisfied that I truly understood these lessons—if God could have trusted me—then I believe He would have prospered me financially since my soul would have been prospering. (*See* III John 2.)

Indeed, if I had only acknowledged God as being the true source for gratification and validation—if I had only yielded complete control to Him—then God would have had little, if any, reason to lead me into the wilderness. Instead, I looked to money as being the solution to my problems. Even though I tithed (and sometimes double-tithed), even though I freely gave to the poor, money nevertheless became an idol because I put it ahead of God. As such, God took me to the proverbial woodshed.

Of course, I know what some readers may be thinking. Since God doesn’t tempt us with evil (*see* James 1:13-15), it would be impossible for Him to lead us into a period of testing, such as the one I encountered. Right?

Nope!

Even though God may not tempt us with evil, the Scripture is quite clear that God can lead us to where He knows the devil is waiting. (Just ask Jesus.) Moreover, there is nothing in Scripture intimating that God could never lead us into a dry time. In fact, the Bible clearly states in Deuteronomy 8:5—the very passage that Jesus quoted during His wilderness experience—that God chastens those whom He loves. Likewise, Paul writes that God allowed a “messenger of Satan” to buffet him. (*See* II Corinthians 12:7.)

The simple fact is that a wilderness experience is a time of chastening. It is a time for correction and training. It’s a time when God directs special attention toward the life of the person who is being transformed. The wilderness is where character is revealed. It is the time when a person realizes just who he is, and where he is headed.

Often, people give up while they are in the wilderness. Remember the story of the Israelites who failed to enter the Promised Land? The nation of Israel missed their opportunity to leave the wilderness when they faced, what seemed to be, insurmountable obstacles to their success. When ten of the twelve spies who had returned from the Promised Land reported that the land was filled with giants (*see* Numbers 13:32-33), the people became so discouraged that some actually suggested returning to Egypt. (*See* Numbers 14:3-4.) They believed that God had let them down. Instead of looking back at the parting of the Red Sea and the miraculous Exodus from Egypt, they could only imagine a future filled with defeat and failure. Thus, what should have been only a small trip through the wilderness ended up lasting forty years. (*See* Numbers 14:33.) People who should have survived this trip instead died in the desert.

Fortunately, not everyone died in the wilderness. Joshua, one of only two spies to speak optimistically about their chances of conquering the land, survived the forty years of wandering. He would lead the children of Israel across the Jordan River, into the territory that God had promised.

By the way, did you know that the Hebrew word for *Joshua* is the same as the Greek word for *Jesus*? Both names mean “God who saves us.”⁴³ Just as Jesus would realize centuries later, Joshua understood that he would survive his wilderness experience. God had said that Joshua would be there for forty years, but that God would let him enter the Promised Land. With that sense of perspective, he remained faithful to God while wandering in the desert. As a result of his faithfulness, God would later entrust him with the responsibility of leading the Israelites after the death of Moses.

It is the wilderness experience that separates the true man (or woman) of God from the person who merely pays lip-service to the cause of Christ. During a wilderness expe-

rience, a body will realize just how much he depends upon gratification, validation, and control.

Be that as it may, if a person could truly lessen his desires for gratification, validation or control, then wouldn't wilderness experiences become less necessary? Naturally, there may be times when an unavoidable wilderness lies on the shortest path between one's present situation and one's future success. Even the Israelites had to go through their wilderness in order to reach Canaan—although they should have done it in only a few weeks and not forty years. With that being said, if there is, in fact, a way to limit one's exposure to the wilderness, wouldn't the minimization of these three desires achieve such an end?

Certainly, there are some wildernesses that God would otherwise have us avoid. These are the self-imposed exiles that result whenever we reject God's Plan for our lives. These are the times when God must transform the soil of our hearts into fertile ground, free of the rocks and thorns that would make us susceptible to peer pressure or the cares and concerns of this world. (*See Matthew 13.*)

Indeed, if our hearts were already softened to the Word of God, we could thrive even in the midst of persecution, secure in God's validation and control, since the Word of God would reach down to the very centers of our souls. (*See Matthew 13:21.*) Likewise, if our hearts were not easily distracted by materialism and greed, but instead were focused upon the big picture—*i.e.*, God's Plan for our lives—then we could overcome the cares and worries that would try to choke the Word of God from our hearts. (*See Matthew 13:22.*) Indeed, there would be little, if any, need for God to chasten us as His Word would bear fruit in our lives—thirty-, sixty-, and even a hundred-fold. (*See Matthew 13:23.*)

Temptation always begins with our desire for instant gratification. The first temptation a Christian will ever face

will not be one to commit sin. Instead, it will be a temptation to fulfill a natural physical desire immediately.

Jesus was hungry. Jesus needed food to survive. However, when faced with the opportunity to manipulate the world so that His need would be met right then and there, He decided to wait patiently for God to provide for His longing. As a result, He had the strength of character to stand up to Satan when He was tempted to commit flagrant violations of God's law later in His wilderness experience.

Like Jesus, your need for instant gratification may center upon food. Whatever your physical need may be, keep this in mind: How (and when) you choose to gratify a desire will determine your susceptibility to further temptations. Even a Godly desire left unchecked may prove to be a weakness. The longer you can resist gratifying a desire, the more resistant to temptation you will become.

This is especially true with respect to the issue of sexuality. Sexual intimacy is one of the few things capable of bringing gratification, validation and control all at once. Hence the reason the drive for sex is so powerful.

Throughout the ages, people have knowingly risked their families, their finances, their emotional stability, and even their lives for just a few minutes of sexual pleasure. Given the inherent risks associated with illicit sexual activity, one who engages therein will invariably place too much emphasis in fulfilling their desires for gratification, validation and control.

Perhaps this is why the acts of fornication, adultery and homosexuality are expressly condemned in Scripture. It's not that God hates fornicators or adulterers or homosexuals. On the contrary, He loves them! However, our Heavenly Father, the Supreme Arbiter of Objective Truth, is looking for *disciples*—for persons who can *discipline* their desires for gratification, validation and control by subordinating the same to His Will.

Since illicit sexual behavior runs counter to these objections, it follows that one cannot be a disciple of Christ and simultaneously practice such acts. Indeed, a person who engages in illicit sexual behavior lacks the requisite characteristics for being a disciple of Christ. Unless and until he is delivered from sexual addiction through the power of the Holy Spirit, such a one will always place pleasure ahead of God's Purpose.

In the final analysis, one who cannot subordinate his desires to God's Plan will end up being controlled by the forces of darkness. Conversely, a person who can subordinate his desires to God's Plan will have little need for a wilderness experience. Indeed, such a one will have the requisite faith to pray, "And lead us not into temptation."

Chapter
EIGHTH SEMESTER:
“BUT DELIVER US FROM EVIL”



Up to this point, we have studied the Model Prayer, parsing each verse in search of the particular characteristics that God seeks to develop in each of our lives.

Throughout our examination, we have operated under a single presumption: If we develop these characteristics to such a degree that they are made manifest whenever we pray, God shall have little (if any) reason to bring testing or chastening to our lives. In layman’s terms, if our hearts are pure, and if our prayers truly reflect what is in our hearts, then chastening shall be unnecessary; as such, we may pray for God to lead us away from temptation. However, if we ever fail to subordinate our desires for gratification, validation and control to the Plan and Purpose of God, then our desires will actually invite temptation. (*See, e.g., I Timothy 6:9, James 1:14.*)

Before one reads too much into the previous paragraph, one should not commit the error that Jesus disciples once made. After Jesus had healed a particular blind man, the disciples assumed incorrectly that the blindness was punishment for sin—if not for the man’s sin, then certainly for that of his parents. (*See John 9:2.*) Jesus replied, “Neither hath

this man sinned, nor his parents: but that the works of God should be made manifest in him.” (John 9:3)

It would be easy to assume that a person who is besieged with tribulation must have done something to invite it. It would be easy to assume that such a one has disobeyed God, has lacked faith, or has otherwise failed to develop the requisite characteristics to avoid such troubles. Since we are incapable of searching the hearts of men, such assumptions would be improper. Indeed, by judging our neighbor, we run the risk of falling into temptation ourselves. (*See generally* Matthew 7:1, I Corinthians 10:12.) Even worse, we will have disregarded the lessons that we may have just learned from the Lord’s Prayer.

Even if we could make such assumptions without experiencing repercussions, the fact remains that, in at least some cases, we would be wrong. In some instances, the afflicted person may, in fact, possess a pure heart, with all the characteristics requisite for God’s blessing and favor.

In such cases, I do not necessarily believe that God has led the person to the place of tribulation. It is possible that such a one may be feeling the ill effects of another person’s wilderness experience—after all, the verse does read, “Lead *us* not into temptation, but deliver *us* from evil.” It could also be that Satan has attacked the person as a direct result of his godliness; after all, as Paul wrote to Timothy, “Yea, and all that will live godly in Christ Jesus shall suffer persecution.” (II Timothy 3:12) Then again, this wilderness experience may well be a necessary precursor to a time of prosperity and success; the shortest path between the status quo and ultimate victory will sometimes take a person to a dry and dusty place. Regardless of the reason, trouble will eventually come to every Christian.

The difficulty that some Christians face when they enter a period of testing comes in understanding the reason for

the trial. Is it chastening from God, or is it persecution from Satan?

For example, some Christians have a “martyr” complex. Whenever these Christians experience any inconvenience—however great or small—they will attribute its cause to a satanic attack. By characterizing the tribulation as being some kind of attack, such a person may derive a certain measure of validation that he would otherwise not have, to wit: To be attacked by Satan implies that one is a target of the devil. If one is a target of the devil, then one must be doing a great work for God. It follows that if one is doing a great work for God, then such a one must be very important to God’s Plan.

On the other hand, there are some Christians who are completely the opposite. These Christians have a “woe is me” complex. Every time something goes wrong, they automatically assume that they are to blame. Although they may, in fact, be pure in heart—although they may have subordinated their desires for gratification, validation and control to the plan of God—they nevertheless fail to recognize that Satan is attacking them for their faithfulness to God.

For persons situated in either extreme, a study of the Model Prayer is necessary.

Both types of Christians need to become secure in the Father’s divine love and supreme objectivity. The person with the “woe-is-me” complex needs to understand that God loves him and is quite proud of him. At the same time, the “martyr” needs to understand that God is supremely objective, and as such, He will sometimes orchestrate periods of temporary depravation in order to purify one’s character.

Both types of Christians need to focus upon the lofty perch of God’s reputation. The “martyr” needs to subordinate his desire for validation to his greater need for humility and patience. Likewise, the “woe-is-me” Christian needs to

accept what God says about him, discarding anything to the contrary, even the temptation to resort to false humility.

Both types of Christians need to focus upon the advancement of God's Kingdom and control. The "martyr" needs to understand that he is not the star of the show. Likewise, the "woe-is-me" Christian needs to abandon the self-criticism and regret that sometimes comes with tribulation, choosing instead to embrace the calling that God has placed in his heart.

Both types of Christians need to focus upon the daily provision of God. The "martyr" needs to understand that God provides for our needs on an as-needed basis. Likewise, the "woe-is-me" Christian needs to realize that God actually wants to supply all of our needs.

Both types of Christians need to focus upon the forgiveness of God. The "woe-is-me" Christian needs to realize that God has forgiven him; as such, he needs to abandon the feelings of condemnation. Likewise, the "martyr" needs to beware of the temptation to become unforgiving, especially if he tends to castigate those who oppose him as being agents of the devil.

In the final analysis, each of the aforementioned traits is, in fact, the very characteristics requisite for one to be delivered from evil. Perhaps this is why "deliver us from evil" is placed after "lead us not into temptation" in the Model Prayer.

A person who has been led into a wilderness experience by God—just as the Israelites and Jesus were—needs to refine these characteristics if he ever plans to advance to the next level. Likewise, a person who has not been led by God into a place of temptation—but who instead has been attacked by the devil—needs to exercise these character traits just as Jesus did on the cross. In either instance, if the afflicted person demonstrates these traits, he will experience

God's grace and mercy, and the very angels of Heaven will minister to him.

In the Bible, evil is personified by Satan and his demons. Although some have argued that this personification is merely a figurative illustration, I disagree. I believe that Satan and his demons are real. Be that as it may, even from a figurative perspective, logic dictates that if certain steps were taken in the Bible to defeat Satan, then these steps, if taken today, would allow us to overcome evil.

Matthew 17 illustrates such an instance:

And when they were come to the multitude, there came to him a certain man, kneeling down to him, and saying, (v. 14)

Lord, have mercy on my son: for he is lunatick, and sore vexed: for oftentimes he falleth into the fire, and oft into the water. (v. 15)

And I brought him to thy disciples, and they could not cure him. (v. 16)

Then Jesus answered and said, O faithless and perverse generation, how long shall I be with you? how long shall I suffer you? bring him hither to me. (v. 17)

And Jesus rebuked the devil; and he departed out of him: and the child was cured from that very hour. (v. 18)

Then came the disciples to Jesus apart, and said, Why could not we cast him out? (v. 19)

And Jesus said unto them, Because of your unbelief: for verily I say unto you, If ye have faith as a grain of mustard seed, ye shall say unto this mountain, Remove hence to yonder place; and it shall remove; and nothing shall be impossible unto you. (v. 20)

Howbeit this kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting. (v. 21)

In the above passage, Jesus expressly states that some types of demons cannot be exorcised without “prayer and fasting.”

Now, we have spent several pages detailing the proper way to pray. However, we have not discussed the subject of fasting.

Fasting is most simply described as being the willful abstinence from sensual pleasures—most commonly, the abstinence from food. With that said, one who fasts generally also abstains from sex or any other form of physical pleasure. As such, one generally cannot experience gratification if one is fasting.

Fasting has always been associated with periods of intense prayer. In the Old Testament, fasting was associated with utter humility and mourning. (*See, e.g.,* Nehemiah 9:1, Esther 4:3, Psalm 35:13.) Even in recent centuries, periods of fasting have been proclaimed as countries experienced difficult times. During the American Revolution, for example, the Continental Congress proclaimed days of fasting and prayer.⁴⁴ Likewise, in 1832, the United States House of Representatives called upon President Andrew Jackson to recommend a day of national fasting and prayer for deliverance from the “Asiatic cholera.”⁴⁵ Three decades later, President Abraham Lincoln followed suit during the Civil War.⁴⁶

Although fasting is designed to mitigate a person's desire for physical gratification, it is also supposed to be a check on a person's desire to exact control. Isaiah 58:3-5 reads:

Wherefore have we fasted, say they, and thou seest not? wherefore have we afflicted our soul, and thou takest no knowledge? Behold, in the day of your fast ye find pleasure, and exact all your labours. (v. 3)

Behold, ye fast for strife and debate, and to smite with the fist of wickedness: ye shall not fast as ye do this day, to make your voice to be heard on high. (v. 4)

Is it such a fast that I have chosen? a day for a man to afflict his soul? is it to bow down his head as a bulrush, and to spread sackcloth and ashes under him? wilt thou call this a fast, and an acceptable day to the LORD? (v. 5)

From this passage, we may glean that even if a person were to go without food for days on end, if such a one were to "fast for strife and debate," then such a fast would not be acceptable to the Lord. Well, when people strive and debate, are they not trying to exert control over others? Of course! It follows then that if a person wishes to fast in a way pleasing and acceptable to the Lord, such a one needs to stop trying to control other people.

Moving to the New Testament for a moment, what does Jesus say about fasting? Matthew 6:16-18 reads as follows:

Moreover when ye fast, be not, as the hypocrites, of a sad countenance: for they disfigure their faces, that they may appear unto men to fast. Verily I say unto you, They have their reward. (v. 16)

But thou, when thou fastest, anoint thine head, and wash thy face; (v. 17)

That thou appear not unto men to fast, but unto thy Father which is in secret: and thy Father, which seeth in secret, shall reward thee openly. (v. 18)

Notice how Jesus decries the Pharisees for bringing attention to themselves when they fast. The Pharisees sought validation through their fasting. Instead of keeping their fasting private, they wanted the world to see just how pious they were. Jesus said that because of their behavior, they would receive no reward from the Father.

Scripture teaches that fasting is not only a limitation upon one's desire for gratification, it should also be a check on one's desire for validation and control.

Does this sound familiar?

When one fasts in accordance with Scripture, such a one will live out the lessons contained in the Lord's Prayer. Fasting is an expression of humility. ("Hallowed be Thy Name") When one fasts, he subordinates control over his situation to the Plan and Purpose of God. ("Thy Kingdom come, Thy Will be done.") During fasting, one is less concerned about his "daily bread," but is more concerned about the Word of God. When one fasts in accordance with Scripture, one becomes less inclined to promote "strife and debate" (Isaiah 58:4); thus a person in fasting will be more inclined to forgive those who have done wrong to him. ("Forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors.")

Perhaps this explains why Jesus overcame His temptation in the wilderness. While fasting, Jesus was able to keep his desires for gratification, validation and control in check. Thus, when Satan presented Him with opportunities to facilitate these natural desires, He was able to withstand the

onslaught of the enemy. In fact, Jesus had enough strength to command the devil to leave Him. (*See Matthew 4:10.*)

At the end of the day, is this not the objective of deliverance? If one wishes to be delivered from evil, one needs to have the authority to command the forces of darkness to leave his life. This authority comes only from having a heart that is consecrated to the Lord. If one lacks this consecration, then fasting is the quickest way to get there.

James tells us, “Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.” (James 4:7) Fasting is the ultimate expression of submission to God. As we pray, and as we speak to the very forces of darkness, taking authority over their evil works, the devil will flee from us in terror. Then the angels will come to minister to us, giving us grace and mercy from the Father God. (*See Matthew 4:11.*)

After we have submitted ourselves to God and successfully resisted the forces of darkness, the devil will learn just who we are. Conversely, if we attempt to resist the forces of evil without first developing the requisite character, we will be defeated, just as the seven sons of Sceva were. (*See Acts 19:14-17.*) As such, we must develop the character traits depicted in the Lord’s Prayer—(1) security, (2) humility, (3) submission, (4) contentment, and (5) forgiveness—if we expect to overcome evil with good.

I sincerely believe that God wants for every Christian to develop these character traits. If we lack any of these characteristics, God may allow us to enter a wilderness experience where we will experience a certain measure of depravation. How we react to this depravation will determine just how quickly our character is developed—and just how quickly we leave the wilderness.

On the other hand, if we exhibit these character traits in not only how we live our lives, but also in how we pray, then God will have little need to lead us into a wilderness experi-

ence. However, the enemy may nevertheless attack us. If this happens, the strength of character that we have developed through prayer and fasting will be quite sufficient to overcome the forces of darkness that attempt to besiege us.

In the final analysis, no matter how much we pray, or how well we live our lives, tribulation is bound to come in one form or fashion—whether it be from persecution or chastening. However, the purpose of this book is to illustrate how we can avoid as much tribulation as possible—or if we are experiencing tribulation, how we may escape it. (Keep in mind that the title of this volume is NOT *The Godly Path of No Resistance*. It is *The Godly Path of Least Resistance*.)

Epilogue
GRADUATION:
“FOR THINE IS THE KINGDOM,
AND THE POWER,
AND THE GLORY FOR EVER,
AMEN”



In my thirty-three years, I have graduated from high school, college, and law school.

Graduation is an exhilarating experience for the student. First and foremost, the student knows that he has accomplished a prodigious feat. On top of this, hundreds—perhaps even thousands—of people are on hand to commemorate this day of jubilant success. As the student walks on the stage to accept his diploma/degree (as the case may be), the student hears the applause from the crowd and basks in the delight of his friends and family.

As we graduate from the study of the Lord’s Prayer, all praise and glory should go to the Great Teacher, and not to the student. In the final analysis, the student deserves no credit. He has simply taken the tools that were paid for by Christ’s sacrifice—not only on the cross, but in the desert as well. It is Jesus who has done all the heavy lifting. Our graduation is merely a reflection of His determination and faithfulness.

Having been delivered from evil, the student has been preserved by the grace of God. He has seen the Kingdom of God manifest with power and glory. An insurmountable obstacle has been removed from his life, giving the person unfettered access to the love, joy and peace that God promises to His children. For this reason, the delivered person has reason to praise and glorify the Lord.

Graduation is a day for looking forward, but it is also a day for victorious reflection. As we look back on how God has provided for our daily needs, forgiven our sins, and delivered us from evil, we may look forward to the future with “faith, nothing wavering,” (James 1:6) knowing full well that if God be for us, then who can be against us. (*See* Romans 8:31.)

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ENDNOTES



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